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Balancing Psychological Safety and Performance Expectations in Swedish Youth Football aged 17-19: A Qualitative Study of Coaches' Perspectives

Att balansera psykologisk trygghet och prestationskrav inom svensk ungdomsfotboll 17–19 år: En kvalitativ studie av tränares perspektiv

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1.Abstract

The aim of this study was to explore how youth football coaches foster a psychologically safe and development-oriented environment while managing different levels of performance expectations. The study used a qualitative research design, in which five youth football coaches were interviewed using semi-structured interviews. The collected data were analysed using thematic analysis. Psychological Safety and Achievement Goal Theory (AGT) were used as theoretical perspectives to understand how coaches described safety, performance, mistakes, competition, and player development.

The results identified six themes: performance demands, mistakes, long-term development, relationships and structure, competition, and playing time. The findings showed that the coaches did not necessarily view psychological safety and high-performance expectations as opposing goals. Instead, several coaches emphasised that players can be challenged and expected to perform while still feeling safe within the football environment. Effort, learning, and long-term development were generally considered more important than short-term results, while mistakes were described as a natural part of the learning process. Competition and selection were accepted as important parts of youth football, but uncertainty could increase when players did not understand decisions regarding their role or playing time. Relationships, clear communication, predictable structures, and continued individual support were also described as important for creating safety and a sense of belonging.

The study concludes that psychological safety does not require the removal of performance expectations. Instead, how coaches communicate and manage expectations appears important for creating an environment where players can compete, make mistakes, and continue developing without becoming afraid of failure.

Keywords: psychological safety, youth football, performance expectations, coaching, motivational climate, player development

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3.Introduction

Youth football is a team sport where learning, social belonging, and performance demands coexist, but where players do not necessarily experience the environment in the same way. Bopp et al. (2025, p. 584**)** describe welcomeness as young people's level of comfort when participating in a sport. The authors further show that feelings of welcomeness can differ according to racial identity and racialised experiences (Bopp et al., 2025, p. 588)**.** This means that the psychosocial environment is not just about well-being, however is about how norms, attitudes, and signals of belonging affect whether young people feel safe enough to participate fully. In a youth sports context, these experiences can have consequences for engagement and the decision to continue, making the "environment" a central part of the development mission itself (Bopp et al., 20255, p. 589).

In more structured and performance-oriented environments, the issue of psychosocial environment is also linked to how expectations and support are organized around the player. Emmonds et al. (2026, pp 6-7) explain that talent development environments in English girls' soccer are often viewed positively by several stakeholders, but that differences between the perceptions of players, parents, and coaches still emerge. This is especially clear when expectations are not synchronized, which means that the same environment can appear supportive from one perspective but unclear or pressuring from another. The study thus highlights that psychosocial quality in youth soccer is not simply a "feeling in the team," but also a consequence of how goals, demands, and support are communicated and coordinated in everyday life (Emmonds et al., 2026, pp. 5-6). In practice, this means that the coach's environment-building work needs to be understood as both relationship work and performance logic management.

A coaching-oriented way to frame this is to view the environment as something that can be designed through norms, structure, and communicative choices. UK Coaching (n.d.) states that coaches need to "understand the environment" and actively form situations in which participants feel appreciated, supported, and welcome, while making sure the environment is challenging enough to promote development. The guide emphasizes that a sustainable development environment balances security and learning risks: players need to feel a sense of belonging and feel that it is possible to try, fail, and adjust without being socially punished (UK Coaching, n.d.).

4.Background

4.1 Youth football in Sweden

Sweden provides a relevant context for this study because football is the largest organised sport in the country. In 2025, Sweden had 2,846 active football clubs, with more than 1.3 million members and over 600,000 active players. Football also accounts for more than 40% of all organised sport activities in Sweden (Svenska Fotbollförbundet, n.d.).

Youth football in Sweden is an important context for young players' sporting and personal development. The Swedish Football Association separates child football, for players up to 12 years old, from youth football, which begins at 13 years old. This distinction is relevant because the football environment gradually becomes more structured and competitive as players get older (Svenska Fotbollförbundet, n.d.).

In child football, the main focus is on enjoyment, effort, learning, and long-term development rather than results. However, in youth football, players may have different motivations. Some participate mainly for enjoyment and friendship, while others aim to develop and compete at a higher level. From 15 to 19 years old, players also move into 11-a-side football, where tactical, physical, and competitive demands increase. Therefore, Swedish youth football is a relevant setting for studying how coaches balance development, high expectations, and a psychologically safe team environment (Svenska Fotbollförbundet, n.d.).

4.2 Coaches' role in youth sport

The role of a coach in sport extends beyond improving athletes' technical and tactical skills. Birmingham City University (n.d.) explains that a sports coach helps athletes of different ages and abilities reach their sporting potential. This includes understanding athletes' strengths and weaknesses, maintaining motivation, analysing performance, and providing training that can improve both individual and team development. From this perspective, coaching involves both sport-specific knowledge and the ability to communicate, teach, solve problems, and work effectively with people.

Acet et al. (2017, pp. 3-4) describe the coach as a leader who has an important role in guiding players and supporting the development of the team. Coaching involves more than teaching technical and tactical aspects of football, as the coach is also responsible for organising the team, creating cooperation between players, and helping individuals work towards common goals. Acet et al. (2017, pp3-4) explain that coaches should support players physically, psychologically, and socially in order to create suitable conditions for development and performance. Acet et al. (2017, p. 4) further explain that an important part of the coaching role is to communicate with players, provide guidance, and support them in taking responsibility. The coach is also responsible for recognising individual abilities and using these abilities in a way that contributes to the development of the whole team. Acet et al. (2017, p. 4) describe successful coaching as involving care for players, belief in their potential, and an ability to create an environment where players feel valued. The role of the coach can therefore be understood as both a leadership and developmental role, where the coach influences not only performance but also the social and psychological environment surrounding the players.

This social and psychological aspect of team environment can also relate to psychological safety. Edmondson (1999) describes psychological safety as a shared belief within team members that the team is safe for interpersonal risk-taking. Edmondson (1999) further explains that psychological safety is related to learning behaviour within teams, as individuals may be more willing to ask questions, seek feedback, discuss mistakes, and share information when they feel safe within the team.

4.3 Performance anxiety

Cleveland Clinic (2024) describes performance anxiety as an intense stress response that can occur when a person is placed “on the spot” and feels expected to succeed. The source also explains that performance anxiety is not limited to stage performances, but can also appear in sport. Symptoms may include increased heart rate, shaking, sweating, tense muscles, shortness of breath, nausea, and difficulty focusing. This is important in youth football because high expectations may affect how players experience mistakes, competition, and pressure. Therefore, performance anxiety is relevant for understanding how coaches can create an environment where players feel challenged but not overwhelmed.

Ho et al. (2026, p 21) describe performance anxiety as a psychological state that can influence athletes' ability to perform under pressure. Ho et al. (2026, p. 21) also explains that research on performance anxiety has developed from an early focus on stress and competitive anxiety towards a broader understanding that includes self-confidence, emotional regulation, coping strategies, motivation, and mental health. Ho et al. (2026, p. 21) further explain that the motivational climate has become an increasingly important area within research on performance anxiety in sport. This is especially relevant in youth football, where the environment surrounding the player may influence how expectations, competition, mistakes, and success are experienced.

Performance-related expectations can also be influenced by the coach. Dunn et al. (2022, p. 1) describe coaches as an important source of performance-related pressure and expectations in sport. Dunn et al. (2022, p. 2) further explain that coach pressure may increase as athletes become older and move into more competitive environments where greater emphasis is placed on performance and winning. The study also showed that athletes generally perceived more performance pressure from coaches than from parents.

4.4 High expectations in youth sport

High expectations are common in youth sport, especially when young athletes become older and the sporting environment becomes more competitive. Expectations can come from coaches, parents, teammates, and the athletes themselves. Kids Sports Psychology (n.d.) explains that expectations may become pressure when young athletes feel that they must be perfect, avoid mistakes, perform well for others, or not disappoint coaches and parents. The source also argues that this pressure can make athletes overthink, play too safely, or focus too much on results instead of effort and development.

Merkel (2013, p. 152) explains that youth sport can have both positive and negative effects on young athletes. On the positive side, sport can support physical activity, social development, self-esteem, and healthy habits. However, Merkel (2013, p. 156) also describes how youth sport may become harmful when adults place too much emphasis on winning, early specialization, and unrealistic expectations. For example, pressure from parents and coaches can contribute to stress, anxiety, reduced confidence, and athletes leaving sport. This shows that high expectations are not automatically negative, but they need to be managed carefully.

In youth football, this is especially relevant because players are often developing physically, emotionally, and socially while also facing selection, competition, and performance demands. Therefore, coaches need to communicate expectations in a way that supports effort, learning, and long-term development rather than fear of failure. High expectations can be useful when they challenge players, but they may become harmful if they create pressure, anxiety, or a feeling that mistakes are unacceptable.

4.5 Development-Oriented Coaching Climate

A development-oriented climate can be understood as an environment where learning, improvement, and long-term development are emphasised alongside performance. Chazan et al. (2022, p. 41) describe mastery-oriented approaches as focusing on learning, improvement, and developing competence. In contrast, performance-oriented approaches place greater emphasis on demonstrating ability in comparison with others and showing competence through performance. Chazan et al. (2022, p. 42) further explain that these different approaches can influence how individuals understand success, effort, and mistakes.

The way coaches communicate, and support players can also contribute to the environment in which development takes place. Acet et al. (2017) describe training and instruction, social support, and positive feedback as different dimensions of coaching behaviour. These behaviours are relevant when considering how coaches can support player development without focusing only on immediate sporting results.

In youth football, development is also influenced by how expectations and support are organised within the environment. Emmonds et al. (2026, pp. 5-6) explain that talent development environments in English female youth football involve several areas connected to player development, including achievement-related communication, support, and the alignment of expectations between players, parents, and coaches. Emmonds et al. (2026, pp. 6-7) further highlight that differences can exist in how these groups experience the same development environment. This shows that a development-oriented climate involves both how performance and development are communicated and how players are supported within the football environment.

4.6 Problem formalisation

Youth football environments include both opportunities for development and expectations related to performance, competition, and progression. As described by Dunn et al. (2022, p. 1), coaches are an important source of performance-related expectations and pressure in sport. Dunn et al. (2022, p. 2) further explain that coach pressure may become more important as athletes become older and continue into more competitive environments. This highlights a challenge for youth football coaches, as they are expected to support player development while also communicating expectations and managing competition.

At the same time, the psychosocial environment may influence how athletes experience these demands. Walton et al. (2024, pp. 558-559) describe psychological safety as important within high-performance sport environments, in which athletes may experience strong performance demands and evaluation. Walton et al. (2024, p. 562) further explain that supportive leadership and clear cultural norms can contribute to environments where athletes feel able to express concerns, acknowledge mistakes, and seek support. Previous research therefore highlights both the presence of performance demands and the importance of creating supportive environments. However, there is still a need to better understand how youth football coaches describe managing these aspects together in everyday practice. This study therefore focuses on how coaches balance performance expectations with the creation of a psychologically safe and development-oriented environment.

5.Aim and research question

The aim of this study is to explore how Swedish youth football coaches describe their work in creating a psychologically safe and development-oriented environment under different levels of performance expectations. The study focuses on how Swedish football coaches understand and communicate success, mistakes, and competition to youth players, as well as how they describe the use of feedback, playing opportunities, and individual support in relation to fairness and player development to.

RQ: How do Swedish youth football coaches foster a psychologically safe and development-oriented climate under different levels of performance expectations?

SQ1: How do coaches communicate success, mistakes, and competition in ways that reflect mastery- or performance-oriented approaches?

SQ2: How do coaches describe their use of feedback, playing opportunities, and individual support to create fairness and player development?

6.Previous Research

The previous research chapter examines existing literature in three areas to provide a deeper understanding of psychologically safe and development-oriented environments in relation to different levels of performance expectations. The three areas are: psychological safety in team environments; coaching leadership and coach-athlete relationships; and performance climate, competition, and pressure in team sports.

6.1 Psychological Safety in Team Environments

Brown et al. (2023, p. 6) describe how a qualitative sports experience is shaped by several factors that together influence how young people perceive their participation. Brown et al. (2023, p. 6) show that joy, social support, a sense of belonging, and the opportunity for development are central components of a positive sports environment. Brown et al. (2023, pp. 11-12) argue that a good youth sports environment should therefore not only focus on results, but also on how the activity can create security, community, and meaning for the players.

Building on the results, Ooms et al. (2025, p. 3) also show that the importance of sport for the well-being of children and young people is closely linked to how the sporting environment is designed. Ooms et al. (2025, p. 22) describe how sport can contribute to mental health by creating structure, social belonging, and possibilities for personal development. At the same time, Ooms et al (2025, pp. 22-24) further emphasize that the effects are not always positive, but are impacted by factors in the environment, such as relationships with coaches, teammates, and the general sport culture. According to Ooms et al. (2025, pp. 22-24), the sports environment must therefore be understood as an important part of how young players feel, develop, and feel included.

Walton et al. (2024, p. 557) examined the role of psychological safety in relation to mental health within elite sport environments. Walton et al. (2024, pp. 558-562) argue that high-performance sport is often characterized by strong performance demands, public evaluation, and power differences between athletes and coaches, which may create barriers to openness and help-seeking. Psychological safety is therefore presented as an important part of creating environments where athletes feel able to express concerns, admit mistakes, and show vulnerability without fearing unfair negative consequences. Walton et al. (2024, pp. 559-562) also emphasise that psychologically safe environments should not only reduce psychological harm, but actively support well-being through clear cultural norms, supportive leadership, and appropriate structures for mental health support. Walton et al. (2024, p. 562) further suggest that coaches and organisations play an important role in shaping whether athletes feel safe to be authentic and seek help when needed. This study is relevant because it highlights how psychological safety can be influenced by both interpersonal relationships and the wider sporting environment.

Building on the importance of psychological safety within sport environments, Gould et al. (2012, p. 80) examined how the psychosocial climate created by coaches was related to developmental experiences among young athletes. Gould et al. (2012, p. 81) study included 239 youth participants and focused particularly on caring and motivational climates within sport. The findings showed that athletes who perceived their coaches as creating caring and mastery-oriented environments were more likely to report positive developmental experiences. In contrast, an ego-oriented climate was more strongly associated with negative experiences such as stress, social exclusion, and negative group dynamics (Gould et al. 2012, pp. 85-86). Gould et al. (2012, pp, 85-86) therefore highlight the important role of coaches in developing the social and psychological conditions surrounding young athletes. A caring climate was characterised by athletes feeling safe, supported, respected, and valued within the sporting setting.

Extending this focus from the immediate coach-created climate to the wider football environment, Crawley and Hills (2023, pp. 38-40) examined how environmental factors influenced the psychosocial needs and development of players within an elite youth football academy. Using a qualitative case study over nine months, the authors found that organisational culture, communication, and shared understanding played an important role in shaping players' psychosocial development (Crawley and Hills 2023, pp. 44). Crawley and Hills (2023, p 39) that successful talent development environments were often characterised by open communication, support for autonomy, holistic development, and a coherent organisational culture. However, the

authors also identified an intention-action gap, where psychosocial development was considered important in principle but was not always consistently embedded in everyday practice (Crawley and Hills 2023, pp 44-45). Crawley and Hills (2023, p. 54) therefore show that a supportive psychosocial environment is not created only through individual coach behaviour, but also through the wider structures and culture surrounding the players. This complements Gould et al. (2012) by broadening the perspective from coaching climate to the overall youth football environment.

6.2 Coaching Leadership and Coach-Athlete Relationships

Gomes et al. (2022, p. 171) describe leadership as more than isolated coach behaviours and argue that effective leadership is linked to how clearly coaches communicate their philosophy, how this philosophy is reflected in practice, and how coaches evaluate whether their leadership is working. Their findings showed that greater congruence between leadership philosophy, practice, and criteria was associated with higher perceptions of team performance among youth football players. The study also indicates that athletes viewed coaches as needing to be clearer in how they express and apply their leadership Gomes et al. (2022, p.175).

Research has also shown that specific leadership behaviours are associated with positive outcomes for athletes. Vella et al. (2013, p 557) found that transformational leadership behaviours and the quality of the coach-athlete relationship were both positively related to positive developmental experiences among adolescent soccer players. In particular, individual consideration, intellectual stimulation, and appropriate role modeling appeared to be especially important. Vella et al. (2013, p. 556) further showed that team success in itself was not related to overall developmental experiences, suggesting that the way coaches lead may be more important than winning alone.

In a similar way, Hampson and Jowett (2014, p. 588) found that both coach leadership and the coach-athlete relationship contributed to athletes' collective efficacy. Their results showed that relationship quality added explanatory value beyond leadership behaviours alone, which suggests that leadership in sport should not only be understood in terms of instruction and decision-making, but also in terms of relational qualities such as closeness, commitment, and support. This is consistent with the view that effective coaching is shaped through interaction between behaviour and relationship.

Another relevant perspective is offered by Kenow and Williams (1992. P 344), who found that athletes with higher anxiety and lower self-confidence evaluated coaching behaviours more negatively. This suggests that coaching is not interpreted in the same way by all athletes and that individual characteristics may influence how leadership is perceived. Finally, Acet et al. (2017, p. 7) showed that less experienced football coaches demonstrated more autocratic leadership characteristics than more experienced coaches, which may indicate that coaching style is also influenced by experience level. Taken together, previous research shows that coaching leadership and coach-athlete relationships are closely connected and have important consequences for how athletes develop, perform, and experience the sporting environment.

6.3 Performance Climate, Competition, and Pressure in Team Sports

Haugen et al. (2020, p. 1) examined the relationship between motivational climate, supportive coach behaviour, and personal treatment satisfaction among young soccer players in Norway. The results showed that a mastery climate was positively associated with personal treatment satisfaction, whereas a performance climate was negatively associated with it (Haugen et al. 2020, p.5). The study also found that supportive coach behaviour moderated the relationship between performance climate and satisfaction, suggesting that a performance-oriented environment may be less negative when coaches also provide support and encouragement. (Haugen et al 2020, p. 7). These findings indicate that competition and performance demands do not operate in isolation, but are shaped by how coaches interact with players within the team environment (Haugen et al 2020, p. 7).

A broader perspective on motivational climate is offered by Martínez-González et al. (2025, p.1), who investigated how young soccer players perceived the climates created by coaches, parents, and peers, and how these profiles related to sport functioning. Their findings revealed that athletes in an empowering climate profile reported higher autonomous motivation, greater satisfaction of psychological needs, and higher vitality. In contrast, athletes who experienced a more disempowering climate reported higher levels of ego orientation, controlled motivation, amotivation, need frustration, and physical and emotional exhaustion (Martínez-González et al. 2025, p. 8). The study therefore suggests that performance pressure in team sports is not only linked to coaches, but also to the wider social environment surrounding young athletes. It also

highlights that climates characterized by controlling and ego-involving features may contribute to more maladaptive experiences in youth sport (Martínez-González et al. 2025, p.8-10).

Fontana et al. (2022, p. 233) further demonstrate how motivational climate may be related to emotional pressure in sport. Their study explored the relationship between athletes' perceptions of team motivational climate and their experiences of sport shame Fontana et al. (2022, p. 234). The results showed that caring and task-involving climates were negatively related to result shame, whereas ego-involving climates were positively related to both process shame and result shame (Fontana et al. 2022, p. 237). According to Fontana et al. (2022, p. 238), athletes in ego-involving climates may be more likely to experience shame when they make mistakes, fail to perform well, or do not meet expectations linked to winning and comparison. These findings are important because they suggest that performance-oriented climates may increase the emotional pressure athletes experience, particularly when success is defined in normative rather than developmental terms (Fontana et al. 2022, p. 239).

Similar patterns can be seen in the study by Ryska and Yin (1999, p. 335), who examined goal orientations and perceived sport competence among recreational and competitive youth soccer players. Their results showed that athletes participating in recreational leagues reported greater mastery-oriented team climate than athletes in competitive leagues (Ryska and Yin 1999, p. 340). Ryska and Yin (1999, pp. 340-341) also found that league structure contributed to differences in how motivational climate was experienced, indicating that competitive environments may be more likely to foster ego-involvement. Ryska and Yin (1999, pp. 340-341) also argue that a mastery-oriented team climate can promote more adaptive motivational development, whereas higher levels of competition may increase the importance of comparison and external standards of success. This makes the study relevant for understanding how the structure of team sports can shape the balance between healthy competition and performance pressure.

Taken together, previous research demonstrates that the psychosocial environment in youth sport is influenced by several interconnected factors, including psychological safety, coach-athlete relationships, leadership behaviours, and the motivational climate surrounding athletes. Studies have shown that supportive, caring, and mastery-oriented environments are generally associated with more positive developmental experiences, while controlling, ego-oriented, and highly performance-focused environments may contribute to stress, shame, exclusion, and reduced satisfaction. However, these factors have often been examined separately. Less attention has been

given to how youth football coaches understand and manage these different elements simultaneously in everyday practice, particularly when performance expectations increase. This creates a need to further explore how coaches attempt to maintain a psychologically safe and development-oriented environment while also managing competition, selection, playing time, mistakes, and expectations of performance.

7.Theoretical perspective

The theoretical framework of this study is based on Psychological Safety and Achievement Goal Theory. Psychological Safety is used to understand how coaches create environments where players feel able to communicate, make mistakes, and participate without fear of negative consequences. Then Achievement Goal Theory (AGT) is used to examine how coaches communicate success, effort, competition, and development through mastery- and performance-oriented approaches.

7.1 Psychological safety

A theory that can be applied to better understand how mental health and performance are related to each other is psychological safety. Edmondson (1999, p. 350) explains that psychological safety in the workplace plays a crucial role in team performance and success. Edmondson (1999, pp. 354-355) further believes that a psychologically safe work environment is one where employees feel free to be themselves, take their own initiatives, express their opinions, and make mistakes without fear of being ostracized from the group. In this trusting environment, where individuals have open and constructive communication, successful collaboration and interpersonal learning are demonstrated, something that is particularly necessary to be able to navigate and perform in a complex and changing world (Edmondson, 2019, p. 20).

7.1.1 Psychological safety in work environment: Edmondson's 's perspective

In workplace environments, Edmondson (2019, pp. 30-31) emphasises that individuals do not always communicate what they know, particularly when speaking up involves interpersonal risk. Employees may recognise problems, disagree with decisions, or need assistance while still choosing to remain silent because they fear appearing incompetent, negative, or disruptive. This

creates an important challenge for organisations, as valuable information may remain unspoken even when individuals are aware that something is wrong. Psychological safety is therefore important because it creates conditions in which employees are more willing to communicate concerns, uncertainties, and different perspectives rather than protecting themselves through silence (Edmondson, 2019, pp. 34-35).

Edmondson (2019, pp. 53-60) illustrates the potential consequences of fear and silence through the Volkswagen emissions scandal. The case demonstrates how organisational pressure, ambitious performance targets, and leadership practices can contribute to an environment where employees become reluctant to challenge decisions or communicate problems upwards. The importance of the example lies not only in the actions of individual employees, but in the organisational environment surrounding those actions. Edmondson uses the case to demonstrate how fear can discourage open communication and allow problematic practices to continue when individuals do not perceive speaking up as safe. Consequently, a lack of psychological safety can affect an organisation's ability to identify problems and respond before they become more serious.

Psychological safety is particularly important for organisational learning because improvement requires individuals to exchange information, acknowledge uncertainty, and discuss unsuccessful outcomes. Edmondson (1999, p. 366) found that psychological safety was associated with learning behaviour in work teams, suggesting that teams need an environment where interpersonal risks can be taken in order to learn effectively. Edmondson (2019, p. 26) further argues that organisations operating in uncertain and complex environments depend on employees being willing to contribute information, questions, and concerns. Psychological safety does not guarantee successful performance, but it provides conditions in which problems can be discussed and learning can occur rather than being restricted by fear and silence.

7.1.2 Creating a fearless organisation: Edmondson’s leadership perspective

Creating psychological safety within an organisation does not happen automatically and leaders have an important role in developing this type of environment. Edmondson (2019, pp. 158-159) explains that leaders can influence whether individuals feel comfortable expressing their opinions, asking questions, and admitting when something has gone wrong. The way a leader communicates and responds to others can therefore have an impact on whether individuals feel safe enough to participate. Edmondson (2019, p. 159) presents three important practices that leaders can use to create psychological safety: setting the stage, inviting participation, and responding productively.

The first practice is setting the stage**,** which focuses on creating a shared understanding of the work and what is expected from the group. Edmondson (2019, p. 162) explains that leaders need to recognise that uncertainty, mistakes, and failures can be a natural part of the work. Instead of expecting everything to be done perfectly, leaders can create an understanding that learning and cooperation are necessary to improve. Another important part is to create a shared purpose where individuals understand why their contribution is important (Edmondson 2019, p. 166). This can help create an environment where asking questions, sharing information, and discussing mistakes are seen as part of the learning process.

The second practice is inviting participation. Edmondson (2019, pp. 167-170) argues that leaders cannot expect individuals to automatically express their thoughts and concerns, especially when there are differences in status and authority. Leaders therefore need to actively create opportunities for individuals to participate. This can be done by asking questions, showing interest in different perspectives, and encouraging individuals to share their knowledge and opinions (Edmundson, pp. 170-173). By inviting participation, leaders can show that different perspectives are valued and that individuals are expected to contribute to the group.

The third practice is responding productively, which focuses on how leaders react when individuals speak up, ask questions, or acknowledge mistakes. Edmondson (2019, p. 173) explains that individuals are less likely to continue speaking openly if their contributions are met with criticism, embarrassment, or rejection. Leaders should instead respond in a respectful and constructive way when individuals take interpersonal risks. However, psychological safety does not mean that leaders should accept every behaviour or remove responsibility. Individuals can still be held accountable while being treated with respect (Edmondson, 2019, p. 178). How leaders respond to mistakes, questions, and concerns can therefore play an important role in creating and maintaining psychological safety within a group.

7.1.3 Psychosocial safety's connection to this thesis

Psychological safety is relevant to the present study because it provides a theoretical perspective for understanding the interpersonal conditions that may contribute to a positive psychosocial environment. The concept focuses on whether individuals feel able to take interpersonal risks, such as expressing opinions, asking questions, seeking support, and acknowledging mistakes without fear of negative consequences (Edmondson, 1999, pp. 354-355). These aspects are

relevant to the purpose of this study, which seeks to understand how youth football coaches describe the creation of a psychologically safe and development-oriented environment.

The theory is also relevant because coaches have a leadership position within youth football teams and can influence the social environment through their communication and interactions with players. Edmondson (2019, p. 159) highlights the importance of leadership in creating conditions where individuals feel able to participate, communicate concerns, and learn from mistakes. Although Edmondson's work was primarily developed within organizational settings, the concepts provide a useful perspective for examining leadership and interpersonal relationships within other team environments. In this study, psychological safety is therefore used to understand how coaches describe their role in creating conditions where young players can communicate, learn, and develop.

Psychological safety is used as the central theoretical perspective rather than as a direct explanation of individual player outcomes. The theory provides concepts that can be used to interpret coaches' descriptions of communication, mistakes, support, participation, and relationships within the team environment. This makes it possible to examine how different coaching practices may contribute to or challenge the development of a psychologically safe environment in youth football.

7.2 Achievement Goal Theory: a conceptual framework

AGT is a motivational theory that explains how individuals understand and evaluate competence in achievement settings such as education and sport (Nicholls, 1984, pp. 328-329). According to AGT, individuals are motivated to demonstrate competence and avoid showing incompetence. However, competence can be understood in different ways, which influences how people experience success, failure, effort, and performance (Nicholls, 1984, pp. 328-329).

Nicholls (1984, pp 328-329) explains that competence can be evaluated through two different conceptions of ability. The first is based on personal improvement, where success is judged through learning, progress, and skill development. From this perspective, individuals experience competence when they improve their performance or develop new abilities. The second is based on comparison with others, where success is determined by demonstrating greater ability than

peers. In this case, competence is judged by how well an individual performs in relation to others rather than by their own improvement.

These different ways of understanding competence form the basis for task involvement and ego involvement within AGT. Task involvement occurs when individuals focus on learning, effort, and personal improvement. Success is therefore connected to developing skills and mastering tasks, regardless of how others perform. In contrast, ego involvement occurs when individuals focus more strongly on demonstrating superior ability compared with others (Nicholls, 1984, pp. 329-330). Success is then connected to outperforming peers, while failure may be interpreted as a sign of lower ability (Nicholls, 1984, p. 328).

Overall, AGT shows that motivation is influenced not only by whether individuals succeed or fail, but also by how they define success. A focus on personal improvement and learning creates a different understanding of competence than a focus on comparison and outperforming others. This distinction is particularly relevant in sport, where athletes are regularly exposed to both opportunities for individual development and comparison with teammates and opponents.

7.2.1 Motivational Climate in Sport

While AGTexplains how individuals define and evaluate competence, researchers have also emphasised the importance of the social environment in shaping these perceptions. Ames (1992, p 263) introduced the concept of motivational climate to explain how the structure and organization of an achievement setting can influence individuals' goal orientations. Within sport, the motivational climate is largely created by coaches through their behaviours, feedback, expectations, and methods of evaluating performance.

According to Ames (1992, pp. 261-263), motivational climates can be categorized into two broad types: task-involving climates and ego-involving climates. These climates communicate what is valued within a particular environment and influence how athletes define success and competence. As a result, the climate established by coaches and other significant individuals can affect athletes' motivation, attitudes, and behaviours.

A task-involving climate focuses more on learning, effort, improvement, and skill development. In these environments, athletes are encouraged to focus on personal progress rather than comparing themselves with others. Success is defined by improvement, persistence, and mastery of skills (Ames, 1992, p. 262). Teachers who create task-involving climates typically recognize

effort, provide constructive feedback, and view mistakes as a natural part of the learning process. (Ames, 1992, p. 267). Consequently, students are more likely to focus on development and long-term improvement rather than solely on outcomes (Ames, 1992, p. 262).

in a ego-involving climate, however, is focusing more on social comparison, competition, and outperforming others (Ames, 1992, p. 262). Within this climate, athletes are often evaluated based on their ability relative to teammates and opponents. Success is associated with winning, being selected, or demonstrating superior performance compared to others. Teachers may unintentionally foster ego involvement when they consistently reward only the most gifted students, emphasize rankings, or focus primarily on performance outcomes (Ames, 1992, pp. 264-265). In these situations, students may become more concerned with demonstrating ability than with developing their skills (Ames, 1992, pp. 263-263).

The motivational climate is particularly relevant in youth sport because coaches play a central role in shaping athletes' experiences. Young athletes often rely on feedback from coaches to interpret their abilities and understand what is valued within the team environment. Therefore, the messages communicated through coaching behaviours can influence how athletes approach training, competition, and personal development. Ames, (1992, p. 263) argue that the social environment within sport contributes significantly to athletes' achievement-related beliefs and behaviours, highlighting the importance of understanding how motivational climates are established and maintained.

From an AGT perspective, motivational climate serves as a key mechanism through which social environments influence motivation. Rather than viewing achievement goals as solely individual characteristics, AGT suggests that the environment can encourage athletes to adopt particular interpretations of success and competence. Understanding motivational climate is therefore essential for examining how coaches contribute to the development of positive sporting experiences and psychosocial environments for young athletes

7.2.2 Mastery-Oriented Climate (Task-involving)

A task-involving climate refers to an environment in which success is defined through learning, improvement, effort, and skill development rather than through comparison with others. Within Achievement Goal Theory, competence is evaluated according to self-referenced standards, meaning that athletes assess their success based on personal progress and mastery of tasks (Nicholls, 1984, p. 329). Ames (1992, p. 162) further argues that task-involving climates

encourage individuals to focus on developing competence through effort and learning, which influences how athletes interpret achievement experiences and evaluate their own performance.

Teachers play a crucial role in creating a task-involving climate through the goals they emphasize and the behaviors they reward. According to Ames (1992, p. 262), environments that value effort, improvement, and skill development encourage students to focus on the learning process rather than solely on performance outcomes. Ames (1992, p. 267) further explains that teachers' behaviors influence how athletes define success and competence within sport settings. By providing constructive feedback, encouraging persistence, and treating mistakes as opportunities for learning, coaches can promote a climate that supports athlete development.

Research has linked task and mastery orientations to several positive motivational outcomes. Duda and Nicholls (1992, p. 294) found that task orientation in sport was moderately associated with satisfaction and enjoyment. Similarly, Ames (1992, p. 262) explains that mastery goals are associated with intrinsic interest, persistence when facing difficulties, and continued engagement in learning. Because competence is linked to personal improvement rather than social comparison, individuals are encouraged to remain focused on effort and skill development (Ames, 1992, p. 262).

Task-involving climates may be particularly important within classrooms, where students develop at different rates and possess varying levels of ability. When teachers emphasise personal improvement rather than comparison with classmates, students can evaluate success in relation to their own progress rather than normative standards (Ames, 1992, pp. 264–265). Furthermore, Nicholls (1984, p. 329) explains that when competence is understood through mastery and self-referenced improvement, greater gains in mastery indicate greater competence.

7.2.3 Performance-Oriented Climate (Ego-involving)

An ego-involving climate refers to an environment in which success is primarily defined through comparison with others and the demonstration of superior ability. Within Achievement Goal Theory, competence is evaluated using normative standards, meaning that athletes judge their success based on how they perform relative to their teammates or opponents (Nicholls, 1984, p 329, p 329). In such environments, athletes are encouraged to focus on outcomes such as winning, selection, and outperforming others. Ames (1992, p. 264) argues that when social comparison

becomes the primary basis for evaluating competence, athletes may become increasingly concerned with demonstrating ability rather than developing it.

Teachers play an important role in shaping performance-oriented environments through the values and expectations they communicate. According to Ames (1992, pp. 264–265), environments become more performance-oriented when evaluation emphasises social comparison, normative success, and outperforming others. Similarly, Duda and Nicholls (1992, p. 290) explain that students' goal orientations are related to their beliefs about how success is achieved in the classroom. Students with an ego orientation are more likely to associate success with demonstrating superior ability and outperforming others (Duda & Nicholls, 1992, p. 290).

Research has shown that ego-oriented achievement patterns can influence athletes' motivation and behaviour in several ways. Because competence is evaluated through social comparison, athletes may become more concerned with demonstrating ability and avoiding the appearance of low ability (Nicholls, 1984, pp. 328–329)**.** Duda and Nicholls (1992, p. 290) found that an ego-involved goal of superiority was associated with the belief that success requires high ability. As a result, achievement may become increasingly connected to outperforming others rather than to personal improvement.

In youth sport, ego-involving climates may create challenges for athletes who develop at different rates or possess varying levels of ability. When success is primarily associated with being better than others, some athletes may have fewer opportunities to experience competence and achievement. Ames (1992, p. 265) argues that excessive emphasis on comparison and performance outcomes can reduce the importance of effort and personal improvement. Furthermore, Nicholls (1984, pp. 337-338) suggests that students who consistently perceive themselves as less capable than their peers may become increasingly focused on avoiding failure rather than pursuing development. Consequently, ego-involving climates may contribute to experiences that prioritize performance outcomes over long-term learning and development.

7.2.4 AGT relevance for this study

Achievement Goal Theory (AGT) provides a suitable theoretical framework for the present study because it focuses on how individuals define competence and success within achievement settings, such as youth sport (Nicholls, 1984, pp. 328-329). More specifically, the theory offers a useful perspective for understanding how coaching practices and team environments influence athletes' experiences and behaviours. Since the purpose of this study is to explore how a positive

psychosocial environment can be created within youth football, AGT helps explain how different motivational climates may affect players' perceptions of success, development, and participation.

A central aspect of AGT is its emphasis on the role of the social environment in shaping achievement-related experiences (Ames, p. 263). The theory suggests that coaches contribute to the creation of motivational climates through their communication, feedback, expectations, and evaluation practices. As a result, AGT provides a framework for examining how coaching behaviours may influence the environment experienced by young athletes. This is particularly relevant in youth football, where coaches often play a significant role in shaping team culture and player development.

Furthermore, AGT is relevant because it distinguishes between task-involving and ego-involving climates, which offer different perspectives on how competence and success are interpreted within sport settings (Fontana et al. 2022, p. 234). These concepts provide a useful lens for exploring how coaches can promote environments that support learning, improvement, and participation, while also understanding how an increased emphasis on comparison and performance may influence athletes' experiences. Therefore, AGT is considered an appropriate framework for the present study as it allows for an examination on how coaches perceive and create motivational climates within Swedish youth football and how their coaching behaviours may contribute to a positive psychosocial environment.

8.Methodology

8.1 Research design

This study adopted a qualitative research design in order to explore how Swedish youth football coaches understand and describe the creation of a psychologically safe and development-oriented environment while managing performance expectations. Bryman (2018, p. 454) explains that a qualitative research approach is appropriate when the aim is to understand participants' experiences, perceptions, and interpretations of social phenomena. Rather than focusing on numerical measurement, qualitative research emphasises words, meanings, and individuals' subjective perspectives. Bryman (2018, p. 563) also explains that qualitative strategies are flexible, allowing researchers to adapt questions during interviews, thereby making them suitable

for exploring sensitive topics. This is supported by Jones (2015, p. 25), who describes qualitative research as grounded in experience, feelings and thoughts. It also uses non-numerical data collected over an extended period to understand and describe concepts that are difficult to express in numbers.

There are some disadvantages when conducting qualitative research. For example, according to Bryman (2018, p. 485), it is debatable whether generalisations can be a problem, given that qualitative methods often use small samples or numbers of participants. It can often be hard to generalise because the study is used in one area, making it hard to see any difference. Bryman (2018, p. 484) also explains that closed, familiar relationships can be formed with the people being interviewed. The research can also be too subjective and have too much scope, which is influenced by the researcher's unstructured interpretations of what is most important and meaningful. Bryman further explains that it is difficult to replicate qualitative studies because the research is often built on the researcher's own understanding and interest.

A qualitative research design is well-suited to this study because it aims to understand coaches' perceptions, experiences, and reasoning regarding the psychosocial environment in youth football. More specifically, the study focused on how coaches understand and communicate performance expectations, mistakes, competition, playing time, relationships, and long-term player development. Since the research question focuses on how coaches foster a psychologically safe and development-oriented climate, it was important to use a method that allowed the participants to explain their perspectives and experiences in their own words.

8.2 Selection

The selection of participants was based on the aim and research questions of the study. Since the study aimed to explore how youth football coaches understand psychological safety, performance expectations, and player development, the participants needed to have relevant experience of coaching youth football. Therefore, a purposive sampling strategy was used. According to Bryman (2018. P. 496), purposive sampling involves selecting participants who have experiences that are relevant to the research aim. In this study, this meant selecting coaches who had experience of working directly with youth football players and who could provide perspectives on the psychosocial environment within football.

The inclusion criteria required participants to have at least one year of experience coaching football players aged 17 to 19, regardless of the youth level. It could be elite or non-elite level. The study did not require the participants to have expert-level coaching qualifications or extensive professional experience. The main focus was instead on their experience and knowledge of working within youth football environments. However, coaches needed enough coaching experience to reflect on situations involving performance expectations, competition, mistakes, playing time, relationships, and player development. The gender of the coaches and the gender of the teams they coached were not used as selection criteria, as the study focused primarily on coaching experiences and perspectives.

The age range of 17–19 years was selected because the study focused on older youth football, where performance expectations, competition, selection, and playing time can become increasingly relevant. Players within this age range are also moving closer to senior football, which may create different expectations regarding performance and development. This made coaches working with these age groups particularly relevant to the purpose of the study. Their experiences provided an opportunity to explore how coaches attempt to challenge and develop players while also creating an environment where players can feel psychologically safe.

Purposive sampling was considered appropriate because the participants were selected based on their ability to provide information that could help answer the research questions. The purpose was therefore not to select participants randomly, but to identify coaches with relevant experience of the environments being examined. This allowed the study to focus specifically on coaches who had experience of managing situations related to performance, development, competition, and the psychosocial environment in youth football.

8.3 Participants

In total, the study included five participants. The original intention was to recruit coaches from different parts of Sweden in order to obtain a broader range of perspectives on the research topic. However, recruitment proved challenging, particularly because data collection took place around the beginning of the football season, when many coaches had limited availability. Some coaches responded but were unable to participate, while others did not respond. As a result, the final sample consisted of five coaches. Two participants were recruited without any previous connection to the researcher, while the remaining three were recruited through existing

professional or personal contacts. Although the final sample was based in Skåne and did not provide the geographical spread initially intended, the participants represented different coaching contexts and offered varied perspectives relevant to the study's aim.

All participants were male and had experience coaching youth football within the age range relevant to the study. The participants had different levels of coaching experience and worked in different roles within their football clubs. This provided a range of coaching perspectives from different youth football environments. Four of the participants were employed full-time by their respective football clubs, while one participant was employed on a 20% basis and had another full-time occupation outside football. The roles of the participants also varied between the clubs. Two participants were employed specifically to coach their teams, while one participant had a broader role that included additional responsibilities within the club. Among the participants, three coached boys aged 19, while one coached girls at the U17 level and one at the U19 level. These differences meant that the participants represented different types of youth football environments and levels of performance expectations.

All participants had direct contact with youth players through their coaching roles and were therefore able to provide perspectives related to psychological safety, performance expectations, competition, player development, and the psychosocial environment. However, the purpose of including participants with different backgrounds was not to generalise the findings to all youth football coaches, but to explore different perspectives relevant to the research questions. To protect participants' confidentiality, identifying information such as names and football clubs is not included in the study. The participants are instead referred to as Informant 1, Informant 2, Informant 3, Informant 4, and Informant 5 throughout the Results section.

8.4 Data Collection

To explore youth football coaches' perspectives on psychological safety, performance expectations, and player development, this study conducted semi-structured interviews. Jones (2015, p. 177) describes a semi-structured interview as a schedule or set of questions that allows the researcher to modify the order of questions and use a flexible approach while still following the purpose of the study. Jones (2015, p. 178) also explains that one advantage of interviews is that participants are able to describe their views and experiences in their own words. This was

suitable for the present study because the aim was to understand how coaches think about and experience different situations within youth football environments.

An interview guide was used to provide the same overall structure for all five interviews. All participants were asked the same main questions and covered the same central topics. However, because the interviews were semi-structured, the order of some questions could be adjusted depending on how the conversation developed. Follow-up questions could also be asked when a participant raised an issue that was relevant to the research questions. Bryman (2018, p. 563) explains that semi-structured interviews provide a balance between structure and flexibility, as the researcher follows predetermined topics while still allowing participants to develop their answers.

The interview guide was written in Swedish because the interviews were conducted with Swedish-speaking participants. This allowed the participants to understand the questions clearly and explain their experiences in their preferred language (The complete interview guide is presented in the appendix). The interviews lasted approximately 30–50 minutes, providing enough time to cover the main topics in the interview guide and allowing participants to develop their answers. Four interviews were conducted face-to-face, while one interview was conducted online via Microsoft Teams. The initial intention was to conduct all interviews in person; however, one participant was only available to participate online.

During the interviews, open-ended questions were used to encourage the participants to provide detailed answers. Jones (2015, p. 177) explains that probing can be used to develop the conversation and encourage participants to further explain their experiences and perspectives. Follow-up questions such as “Why do you think that is?” and “Could you explain that further?” were therefore used when relevant. Although the follow-up questions could differ depending on the participants’ answers, the same main interview structure was maintained throughout the data collection.

8.5 Data Analysis

To analyse the data from the semi-structured interviews, this study used Reflective thematic analysis (RTA) guided by Braun et al. (2016, p. 196), describing a six-phase model. Braun et al. (2016, p. 195-196) explain that (RTA) is not a completely linear process. During the analysis, the researcher may move back and forth between familiarisation, coding, and theme development as the understanding of the data develops. This allows codes and themes to be reviewed and adjusted

throughout the analysis (Braun et al. 2016, p 198-199). Braun et al. (2016, p.192) also emphasise that themes are not simply found in the data but are developed through the researcher's interpretation and engagement with the material. The researcher therefore has an active role in deciding which patterns are relevant and how they should be organised into themes (Braun et al. 2016, p. 192). In the present study, this process was used to identify recurring patterns across the interviews and to develop themes that reflected the coaches' perspectives on the research questions.

The first phase involves becoming familiar with the data by reading and re-reading the interview material (Braun et al. 2016, p. 196). For this study, the interview transcript was read several times to gain an understanding of the participants' responses and to identify initial recurring ideas that are relevant to the research questions. The second phase focuses on generating initial codes by identifying relevant parts of the data (Braun et al. 2016, p. 196). In this study, relevant sections of the transcripts were assigned short descriptive codes based on their content, for example, mistakes, competition, playing time, relationships, and player development. In the third phase, related codes are grouped together to develop potential themes (Braun et al. 2016, p. 198), For this study, codes with similar meanings were compared across the interviews and grouped together into broader categories that could form potential themes. The fourth phase involves reviewing the themes and checking whether they accurately represent the coded material and the overall dataset (Braun et al., 2016, p. 198- 200). In this study, the potential themes were compared with the coded extracts and full interview transcripts, and overlapping themes were revised or combined to create a clearer thematic structure. In the fifth phase (Braun et al. 2016, p. 200), the themes are further defined and given clear names that reflect their content. For this study, each theme was reviewed to clarify its central meaning and to ensure that its name accurately represented the pattern identified across the interviews. The final phase involves writing up the analysis and presenting the themes together with relevant examples from the data (Braun et al. 2016, p. 200-201). In this study, quotations from the interviews were selected to illustrate each theme, and these were followed by analytical interpretations connected to the research questions.

8.6 Ethical Consideration

This study followed the research ethical guidelines described by Vetenskapsrådet (2024). According to Vetenskapsrådet (2024, p. 62-63), individuals who participate in research should receive clear information about the study and provide informed and voluntary consent before participating. The participants should also understand what their participation involves, how the collected data will be handled, and that participation is voluntary.

Before the interviews were conducted, all participants received an information letter describing the purpose of the study, the interview procedure, and how the collected material would be used. The participants were informed that participation was voluntary and that they had the right to withdraw their participation. Informed consent was collected before each interview, and the participants gave permission for the interviews to be recorded.

Confidentiality was also considered throughout the research process. Vetenskapsrådet (2024, p. 67) explains that research data should be handled in a way that protects participants from unauthorised access and that personal data should not be stored for longer than necessary. In the present study, identifying information such as the participants' names and football clubs was not presented in the thesis. Instead, the participants are referred to as Informant 1, Informant 2, Informant 3, Informant 4, and Informant 5.

Although the participants in the study were adult coaches, the interviews concerned their experiences of working with youth football players aged 17–19. The coaches were therefore instructed not to provide names or other identifiable information about individual players during the interviews. This was important in order to protect the privacy of young players who were discussed but were not themselves participants in the study. The collected material was stored safely during the research process and will be deleted after the completion of the study. The information letter and consent form are presented in the appendix.

9.Results

The thematic analysis resulted in six themes that reflected the main recurring patterns identified across the five interviews. The themes were developed because they represented different but closely connected aspects of how the coaches described psychological safety, performance expectations, and player development. Together, the six themes provide a structured presentation of the findings and contribute to answering the research question of the study.

Theme Number	Theme Titel
1	Performance Demands and Performance Anxiety
2	Mistakes as Part of the Learning Process
3	Long-Term Development Over Short-Term Results
4	Relationships, Clarity, and Structure as a Foundation for Safety
5	Competition Without Creating Insecurity
6	Playing Time, Fairness, and a Sense of Belonging

9.1 Performance Demands and Performance Anxiety

One of the main themes identified from the interviews concerned performance demands and the pressure that young football players can experience within their sporting environment. All five informants described performance as a natural part of football, particularly when players become older and move towards more competitive environments. However, the informants also highlighted that the way performance is understood and communicated can influence how players experience these demands. A common distinction was made between focusing on effort and development, and focusing on short-term outcomes such as winning, selection, playing time, or comparison with other players.

Informant 1 described performance as something that should primarily be connected to the player's own effort rather than to the final outcome of a match:

"*To do your best. That is performance. It is not the consequences of what we do. That is not performance, that is an outcome."*
(Informant 1)

The statement shows that Informant 1 made a clear separation between what the player can control and what happens as a result of the performance. From this perspective, the expectation placed on the player is to make an effort and attempt to perform the task rather than to guarantee a particular result. The informant repeatedly returned to the importance of reducing the significance attached to winning and losing in youth football. This did not mean that performance was considered unimportant. Instead, performance was described in terms of effort, courage and the willingness to continue trying. According to the informant, a stronger focus on outcomes can create additional pressure because players may begin to connect mistakes or losses with negative consequences.

A similar perspective was expressed by Informant 2, although this informant worked within a highly performance-oriented football environment. Informant 2 did not describe safety and performance as conflicting goals:

"*I would say that feeling safe is important if you are going to perform well*." *(Informant 2)*

This suggests that high expectations were not viewed as something that necessarily needs to be removed in order to protect players. Instead, the informant considered a safe and predictable environment important for allowing players to perform under demanding conditions. At the same time, Informant 2 described a strong focus on measurable outcomes as particularly problematic for young players. Examples included league position, goals scored, national-team selection and playing time. The informant described how these visible indicators can become central to how players evaluate themselves. Consequently, the pressure experienced by players may not only come directly from coaches but also from the meaning that players attach to selection, statistics and comparison with others.

Informant 3 also described performance pressure as an important challenge, particularly as players become older and move closer to senior football. The informant highlighted that players often experience pressure to be ahead of others in their development:

"*If you are not that guy who is at the very front, then it is stressful for many of the others*." *(Informant 3)*

The comment reflects how current status can become important for young players when they evaluate their own development. Informant 3 described parents, agents and peers as factors that may strengthen this pressure by drawing attention to who is progressing fastest or receiving the greatest opportunities. The informant therefore emphasised the importance of helping players understand that development during adolescence is not always linear. A player who is not currently playing regularly or progressing at the same rate as others may still develop successfully later. In this sense, performance anxiety was connected not only to match performance but also to uncertainty regarding the player's future position within football.

Informant 4 similarly described performance pressure as extending beyond what takes place during training and matches. The informant referred to school, parents, social media and the increasing visibility of exceptionally successful young football players. In particular, the informant described how comparisons with young professional players may affect how adolescents evaluate their own progress:

"*If you have a 16- or 17-year-old today who sees that there is a 17-year-old in Barcelona who has won the Champions League and been decisive, then their career is over.*" *(Informant 4)*

Although expressed in an exaggerated way, the example illustrates the informant's concern that young players may develop unrealistic expectations regarding when success should occur. According to Informant 4, players may begin to interpret the success of others as evidence that they themselves are falling behind. The informant therefore repeatedly returned to the question of why young people play football in the first place. Enjoyment and the desire to play were described as potentially being replaced by expectations of becoming professional, gaining recognition or proving one's ability to others. This suggests that performance pressure can develop through a wider social environment and not only through the direct actions of a coach.

Informant 5 presented a somewhat different view of performance demands. Coming from a high-performance academy environment, the informant described competition as an unavoidable part

of football and stressed that only a limited number of academy players will eventually reach the first team:

"*Football is for few players, not all of you arrive to the first team*." *(Informant 5)*

Compared with the other informants, this perspective placed greater emphasis on accepting the competitive reality of high-performance football. However, the informant did not suggest that players should simply be exposed to pressure without support. Honesty from coaches, emotional development, patience and what the informant described as "healthy competition" were considered important. Players were expected to compete, but also to respect and learn from each other. The informant further described winning as a consequence of the process rather than something that should dominate everyday work. This indicates that even within a highly competitive environment, performance demands can be framed around the process of development rather than only around immediate success.

Overall, the five informants described performance demands as an unavoidable but manageable part of youth football. Their responses suggest that the main challenge is not necessarily whether demands exist, but rather what those demands are directed towards and how they are communicated. Expectations connected to effort, learning and continued development were generally described more positively, while pressure connected to immediate results, selection, status and comparison was viewed as more likely to create uncertainty and performance anxiety. There were also differences between the informants regarding how much competitive pressure young players should be expected to tolerate. Nevertheless, the interviews indicate a shared concern that excessive attention to short-term outcomes can shift the player's focus away from development and increase the psychological pressure associated with football.

9.2 Mistakes as Part of the Learning Process

A second theme identified across the interviews concerned how mistakes were understood and handled within the football environment. The informants generally described mistakes as an unavoidable part of learning and player development. Rather than seeing mistakes as something that should immediately lead to criticism or negative consequences, several informants emphasised the importance of allowing players to try again, reflect on what happened, and

continue participating without becoming afraid of failure. At the same time, the interviews also showed that mistakes were not viewed as irrelevant. Coaches still expected players to learn from them and improve their future actions.

Informant 1 placed particular emphasis on avoiding blame when players make mistakes. The informant described football as a sport where the consequences of an error are already visible to the player, such as losing possession or conceding a goal:

"*By not blaming them when they make mistakes, you constantly try to play it down so that we get brave players who want to try again*."
(Informant 1)

This illustrates how the informant viewed the coach's reaction to mistakes as important for whether players continue to take initiative. The mistake itself was not considered the main problem. Instead, the concern was that negative reactions from coaches or teammates could make players more cautious and less willing to attempt difficult actions. The informant therefore connected the acceptance of mistakes with developing players who are willing to take risks and continue trying. However, this acceptance also required consistency from the coach. If a player was encouraged to take risks but was later substituted or excluded after making an error, the informant argued that the coach could undermine the trust that had previously been created.

Informant 2 expressed a similar perspective and described a learning environment as one where players are able to make mistakes without becoming overly affected by them:

"*You can go into a training week and a training session and not run around being afraid of making mistakes... you try again, but it does not cost so much energy that you lose a larger part of the training or match*."
(Informant 2)

The informant's response suggests that the important issue was not whether mistakes occurred, but how players responded afterwards. A player who remains focused and attempts the action again was considered better positioned to continue learning than a player who becomes mentally occupied by the mistake. Informant 2 also emphasised the importance of players asking questions about what they could do differently. This indicates that mistakes were regarded as opportunities

for reflection and adjustment rather than simply as failures. At the same time, the coach still had a role in helping players recognise what needed to improve.

Informant 3 also described mistakes as a natural part of development and emphasised that players should understand that they do not need to perform perfectly:

"*I don't need to be perfect and things can go wrong, but I am not punished for it. Instead, I get a second chance and a third chance*."
(Informant 3)

This statement demonstrates a clear distinction between correcting a mistake and punishing the individual who made it. Informant 3 explained that coaches may still need to identify what went wrong and provide feedback, but that the mistake should be approached as something the player has not learned *yet*. The focus therefore remained on improvement rather than personal failure. This perspective also suggests that repeated opportunities are important for development, because players need to experience that a mistake does not automatically change how they are viewed by the coach.
Informant 5 similarly emphasised the importance of allowing players to experience setbacks as part of a longer process. Rather than expecting coaches to immediately remove difficulties, the informant argued that players sometimes need time to work through periods of insecurity or failure:

"*Maybe they have to pass a thought process in order to learn and develop as a person and a player, and us coaches need to be there and supportive if it happens*."
(Informant 5)

The response provides a somewhat broader interpretation of mistakes and setbacks than those of the other informants. Informants focused particularly on patience and the understanding that development may take a considerable amount of time. Coaches were expected to support the player and create suitable activities, but not necessarily to remove every difficult experience. The informant also stressed the importance of focusing on factors that the player and coach can control. This suggests that errors and setbacks were viewed as experiences that players need to learn to manage rather than situations that should always be prevented.

Overall, the interviews show a shared understanding that mistakes are an important part of player development. The informants did not suggest that mistakes should simply be ignored. Instead, they described a coaching approach where errors are acknowledged, discussed and used as opportunities for learning, while avoiding reactions that make players afraid of trying again. A recurring pattern was therefore the distinction between correcting a mistake and punishing a player for making one. The findings also indicate that the way coaches respond after mistakes may influence whether players continue to take initiative, reflect on their actions and remain engaged in the learning process.

9.3 Long-Term Development Over Short-Term Results

A third theme identified across the interviews concerned the importance of maintaining a long-term perspective on player development rather than allowing short-term results, selection, or current status to dominate. All five informants described youth football as a developmental process in which players progress at different rates and where current performance does not necessarily determine future potential. A common concern was that young players often focus strongly on what is happening in the present, such as whether they start a match, how much playing time they receive, or how they compare with other players. The informants therefore described different ways of helping players understand development as a longer process rather than something that should be judged from one match, one season, or one period of performance.

Informant 1 strongly emphasised that development in youth football should not be evaluated primarily through match results. Instead, the informant argued that the purpose of youth football is to prepare players for their future development and that coaches therefore need to distinguish between winning a match and developing as a football player:

"*The answer is not to focus on winning; development is not about that. In a few years it is not that interesting who wins the match that happened 2 years ago*."
(Informant 1)

The informant's comments show a clear concern that winning can become too important within youth football. According to Informant 1, successful teams may gradually begin to prioritise results over playing time, development and enjoyment. The informant also described player development as a "marathon", where the aim should be for players to reach their highest level later rather than being judged by how successful they are during adolescence. This perspective

suggests that short-term success can become problematic when it changes the priorities of coaches or makes players believe that current performance is more important than continued development.

Informant 2 presented a similar perspective but placed particular emphasis on making long-term development visible to the individual player. The informant described how young players may struggle to recognise their own progress because their attention is often directed towards the next match or immediate selection:

"*Where were we two months ago? Where were we one month ago? Could we do this three months ago? No, we couldn't. Now we can*."
(Informant 2)

For Informant 2, helping players develop a longer-term perspective required more than simply telling them to be patient. Coaches were described as needing to provide concrete evidence of development through individual meetings, video material and comparisons with the player's previous performances. This allowed the player to evaluate progress against their own earlier level rather than only against teammates. The informant also emphasised that a player may continue developing even during periods of limited playing time. This suggests that long-term thinking was viewed as something coaches need to actively support and demonstrate, rather than something young players will naturally develop themselves.

Informant 3 also highlighted the difficulty young players can experience when their current position does not match their expectations. The informant described a tendency among players to view immediate status as particularly important:

"*I talk to my players about having a career between 20 and 35. That is what is important. Not that you are at the front when you are 17*."
(Informant 3)

The statement illustrates how Informant 3 attempted to broaden the time perspective of players who may be concerned about not currently being selected or progressing as quickly as others. Physical maturation, injuries and differences in individual development were described as factors that can temporarily affect a player's position. The informant therefore used examples of players who developed later in their careers to show that early success is not a requirement for later

achievement. However, the informant also acknowledged that communicating this message can be difficult because young players are often strongly focused on their current situation. Long-term development therefore required repeated conversations rather than a single explanation.

Informant 4 expressed the same concern about the short-term perspective of young players and connected it to changes in the wider social environment. The informant described young people as increasingly accustomed to immediate information, feedback and comparison, which may make it more difficult for them to think several years ahead. Nevertheless, the informant argued that coaches should continue to focus on development rather than offering guarantees about future success:

"I don't know if you will succeed, but if you do these things better, then you will become better football players. But there is no guarantee."
(Informant 4)

This comment demonstrates an approach to long-term development based on improving what the player can influence without promising a particular future outcome. Informant 4 repeatedly emphasised that coaches cannot guarantee that a player will become professional, regardless of how much they train. Instead, the responsibility of the football environment is to provide opportunities for players to continue learning and improving. The informant also stressed the importance of belonging and participation, particularly for players who are currently further behind, as continued involvement may allow development to occur over a longer period.

Informant 5 similarly emphasised the developmental process rather than immediate outcomes. This was expressed through the idea that players and coaches should remain committed to the path they are following rather than changing direction because of an individual result:

"*The coach needs to know that winning is a consequence every day we have to say to ourselves, don't lose the way*."
(Informant 5)

Informant 5's perspective placed considerable emphasis on trusting and respecting the developmental process. Winning and losing were viewed as temporary outcomes within a much longer journey. The informant argued that a team could lose while still remaining on the correct

developmental path if it continued to play and train according to its intended approach. Similarly, achieving a particular goal was not described as the end of development, because another objective would follow. This perspective reinforces the idea that consistency in the developmental process was considered more important than allowing individual results to determine whether progress had been successful.

Overall, all five informants described long-term development as an important counterbalance to the short-term nature of youth football. Players were often described as being strongly influenced by current playing time, selection, results and comparison with others, while coaches attempted to shift attention towards progress over months and years. The findings also show that long-term development was not understood simply as waiting for improvement to happen. Instead, it involved providing feedback, showing evidence of progress, maintaining opportunities for development and helping players understand that different developmental pathways are possible. Across the interviews, short-term results were therefore generally viewed as temporary indicators, while continued learning and improvement were considered more important measures of progress.

9.4 Relationships, Clarity, and Structure as a Foundation for Safety

The fourth theme that was identified across the interviews concerned the importance of relationships, clear communication, and structure in creating a safe and supportive football environment. All five informants described safety as something that was built through everyday interactions rather than through single activities or formal statements. Players were considered more likely to feel secure when they understood what was expected of them, trusted the people around them, and experienced consistency in how coaches communicated and behaved. At the same time, the interviews showed that relationships and structure were closely connected. Clear routines without strong relationships could become impersonal, while good relationships without consistency could create uncertainty.

Informant 1 placed considerable emphasis on the relationship between coach and player and described trust as one of the most important parts of a safe environment:

"*It is not about having a good relationship so you can shout at them. It is about having a good relationship so that they trust you*."
(Informant 1)

The comment suggests that the purpose of the relationship was not simply to create a friendly atmosphere, but to establish confidence in the coach. Informant 1 also emphasised that players have different personalities and needs, meaning that coaches may need to communicate differently with different individuals. Some players may respond to humour, while others may require a more supportive or personal approach. This highlights the importance of coaches being able to adapt their behaviour while still maintaining a clear and consistent way of working. The informant also acknowledged that it may not be possible for one coach to develop the same relationship with every player, which strengthens the importance of having several leaders with different interpersonal strengths.

Informant 2 placed stronger emphasis on predictability and organisation as important parts of safety. According to the informant, players should know what is happening during the week and be able to trust that the coaching staff are prepared:

"*For me, it is an organisation that is predictable in the sense that you have leaders and coaches around the team that you can trust*."
(Informant 2)

The statement shows that safety was understood not only in emotional terms but also through organisation and consistency. The informant described weekly planning, clear communication and repeated routines as ways of reducing uncertainty. If coaches communicate differently from week to week or fail to explain changes, players may become unsure about what is expected of them. Informant 2 also connected this structure to the ability of coaches to give attention to individuals. When the weekly organisation is well planned, coaches have more time to observe players, hold conversations and respond to problems. In this sense, structure was not presented as separate from relationships, but as something that created the conditions for stronger interpersonal support.

Informant 3 similarly highlighted both relationships and clear expectations. The informant described a safe environment as one where players understand the rules and where these rules are applied consistently:

“I think a safe environment is when you have rules of conduct that everyone adapts to and everyone knows which rules apply.”
(Informant 3)

The informant's response indicates that uncertainty can develop when players do not understand the boundaries of the environment. Clear expectations were therefore described as important for both behaviour and communication. However, Informant 3 also stressed that rules alone were not sufficient. The coach-player relationship was described as increasingly important in modern football, particularly because players expect more communication, feedback and personal attention. The informant even suggested that social competence can be more important than technical football knowledge in some situations. This reflects a view of safety as something created through both organisational consistency and interpersonal connection.

Informant 4 also emphasised the importance of consistency, particularly within the coaching staff. The informant argued that players may become uncertain when different coaches communicate different messages:

“*We need to know that we can trust each other, so that one person does not say one thing and another says something else.*”
(Informant 4)

This highlights the importance of alignment among coaches as part of the player's environment. Informant 4 described clear roles within the coaching staff, common rules and repeated communication as important for creating predictability. If players receive different answers depending on which coach they approach, the environment may become less stable. The informant also connected this to broader club values, arguing that principles such as community, equality and togetherness need to be visible in everyday practice rather than simply written in formal documents. This suggests that safety was viewed as something that depends on whether the organisation behaves consistently with what it communicates.

Informant 5 approached the theme more strongly from the perspective of honesty and team cohesion. The informant argued that coaches need to know their players as individuals and understand what may be happening outside football:

"*The coach must know about the players... what happens in their family... to know if he pushes or does not push the player*."
(Informant 5)

The response suggests that a safe relationship requires more than knowledge of football performance. The informant described the player first as a person and emphasised the need to understand emotional and social circumstances when deciding how to communicate or challenge the individual. Informant 5 also described activities outside the football environment as useful for developing stronger relationships and cohesion within the team. Examples included social activities, training in different environments and collaborative experiences. This indicates that safety was also connected to the quality of relationships between players, not only between players and coaches.

Overall, the five interviews show that relationships, clarity and structure were closely connected in the way the informants understood a safe football environment. Players were described as needing to feel seen and respected, but also to understand the expectations, routines and boundaries within the team. The findings suggest that safety is difficult to create through relationships alone if communication is inconsistent, just as clear rules may have limited value if players do not trust the people applying them. Across the interviews, a safe environment therefore appeared to depend on a combination of interpersonal trust, consistent communication, predictable organisation and shared expectations.

9.5 Competition Without Creating Insecurity

A fifth theme identified across the interviews concerned how competition could be maintained without creating insecurity among players. All five informants described competition as a natural and unavoidable part of football, particularly in older youth and performance-oriented environments. However, they differed in how strongly competition should influence selection, playing time, and the everyday training environment. A common pattern across the interviews was that competition was not viewed as problematic in itself. Instead, insecurity appeared to increase when players did not understand decisions, when competition became overly individualised, or when comparison with teammates started to affect relationships and belonging within the group.

Informant 1 described competition for playing time as something that becomes more significant as players become older. The informant argued that younger players should experience more rotation, while older players increasingly become aware of status connected to the starting eleven:

"*If you have a rotation system, which I think you really should have at youth level... then they should accept that it is a rotation environment*."
(Informant 1)

The statement shows that Informant 1 viewed predictability as an important way of reducing the insecurity that competition can create. Rather than removing competition completely, the informant suggested that players should understand how opportunities are distributed and why certain decisions are made. The informant also emphasised that players who are outside the starting eleven deserve an explanation about whether they are being rotated or excluded because of performance. This suggests that competition becomes more difficult to manage when players are left to interpret selection decisions on their own. For Informant 1, transparency and planned rotation therefore appeared to be important tools for protecting trust while still allowing competition to exist.
Informant 2 also considered competition an unavoidable part of football and argued that players need to learn how to deal with it:

"*Competition, it is a part of life actually*."
(Informant 2)

However, the informant did not describe competition as something that should simply determine who receives opportunities. Instead, players needed to understand why they were training in particular positions, what they were expected to develop, and how their individual progress was being evaluated. Informant 2 also described negative behaviours between players as potentially damaging, particularly if stronger players excluded or looked down on teammates who were not currently part of the starting eleven. This suggests that competition was considered acceptable as long as it remained connected to development and did not reduce cooperation or group belonging. In this perspective, the coach's role was not to eliminate competition but to control how competition was expressed within the team.

Informant 3 also recognised the need for competition but expressed concern about environments where players feel they must prove themselves at every training session:

"*I think you need a little competition, but still some security that you know your roles*." *(Informant 3)*

The informant contrasted a more secure environment, where players understand their roles, with one in which every training session feels as though a player's place is constantly under threat. Some competition was considered useful because it could motivate players to improve, but excessive uncertainty was described as a possible source of performance anxiety. Informant 3 therefore appeared to favour a balance where players are challenged without feeling that one poor action immediately changes their position within the team. This highlights an important distinction between competition as motivation and competition as continuous threat.

Informant 4 similarly described competition as something that depends greatly on how the football environment is organised. The informant used positional competition as an example and argued that players may feel more secure if they are able to compete for more than one position:

"*If you have more than one position that you can compete for, I think it will make the psychological aspect easier*."
(Informant 4)

This perspective shows how organisational decisions can shape the experience of competition. If a player believes there is only one possible position available and another player is clearly ahead in the hierarchy, the competition may feel impossible to influence. Allowing players to experience different positions could therefore create more opportunities while also contributing to broader football development. Informant 4 also placed considerable responsibility on coaches, arguing that the environment surrounding competition is largely created through how leaders organise training, playing time, and communication. Competition was therefore not viewed as an individual issue alone, but as something shaped by the structure of the team.

Informant 5 expressed the strongest acceptance of competition as an essential feature of high-performance football. The informant repeatedly used the term "healthy competition" and argued

that players competing for the same position should still be able to support and learn from each other:

"*We create a healthy competition. I can learn from you, you can learn from me." (Informant 5)*

Compared with the other informants, Informant 5 placed greater emphasis on the reality that the best-performing player may receive the opportunity. However, this competitive approach was combined with values such as respect, humility and solidarity. The informant argued that players can compete intensely during training while still maintaining positive relationships outside the immediate competitive situation. This provides an important contrast within the dataset. While some informants emphasised rotation and role security, Informant 5 placed greater weight on selection based on current performance. Nevertheless, all of these perspectives shared the idea that competition should not involve undermining teammates or damaging the wider team environment.

Overall, the five interviews show that competition was generally accepted as an important part of youth football, but that its effect on players depended on how it was organised and communicated. The informants described different approaches, ranging from planned rotation and clear roles to stronger performance-based selection. Despite these differences, all five informants agreed that competition should not lead players to exclude, undermine, or disrespect teammates. The findings therefore suggest that the challenge for coaches is not to remove competition, but to create conditions where players can compete for opportunities while still experiencing clarity, respect, and belonging within the team.

9.6 Playing Time, Fairness, and a Sense of Belonging

A sixth theme identified across the interviews concerned playing time, fairness, and the extent to which players feel that they belong within the team. All five informants discussed, in different ways, how selection decisions and opportunities to play can influence how young players experience their position in the group. Playing time was not described only as a competitive issue, but also as something connected to recognition, motivation, development, and the feeling of being valued by the coach. A recurring pattern was that fairness did not necessarily mean that every player should always receive exactly the same amount of playing time. Instead, the informants

emphasised the importance of transparency, communication, and ensuring that players continued to receive opportunities to develop even when they were not regular starters.
Informant 1 described playing time as becoming increasingly sensitive as players grow older. They described that it is important to talk to the player if they are being left out and why.

"*They need to know if they are being rotated or if they have been dropped*." *(Informant 1)*

This statement highlights the importance of communication when players receive less playing time. For Informant 1, the problem was not simply that a player might start on the bench, but that uncertainty about the reason could affect how the player interprets their position in the team. The informant therefore emphasised that players deserve an explanation when their role changes. Rotation was described as one possible strategy for creating greater predictability and providing opportunities across the squad. However, the informant also recognised that equal playing time becomes increasingly difficult as players grow older and competitive demands increase. Fairness was therefore presented less as complete equality and more as ensuring that decisions are understandable and that players are not permanently excluded from opportunities.

Informant 2 also described playing time as closely connected to how players perceive their value within the team. The informant explained that young players may use match minutes as an indication of how the coach views their ability:

"*Game time can be a very large part of how they see themselves and, through that, what they think I see in them*."
(Informant 2)

This illustrates how selection decisions can carry meaning beyond the match itself. A player receiving limited playing time may interpret this as evidence that the coach has little confidence in them, even when the coach has other reasons for the decision. Informant 2 acknowledged that giving everyone equal playing time was not realistic within the competitive structure of the team. However, the informant emphasised that players who were further from the starting eleven still needed opportunities to develop, follow their individual development plans, and receive meaningful feedback. This suggests that fairness was understood as ensuring continued investment in every player's development rather than guaranteeing identical outcomes.

Informant 3 similarly highlighted the difficulty of maintaining motivation and belonging among players who receive fewer competitive opportunities. The informant described the challenge created by squad sizes where only eleven players can start:

"*I have 27 players in my squad and I can only play eleven. That means some are disappointed, but at the same time you can still do good things for each other." (Informant 3)*

The comment reflects the unavoidable tension between individual expectations and the structure of team sport. Informant 3 acknowledged that disappointment cannot always be prevented, but stressed that players can still contribute to the group when they are not selected. The informant also described how conversations between players about who should or should not be in the team can affect those who are currently outside the starting eleven. This highlights that belonging is influenced not only by coaches' selection decisions but also by the attitudes and behaviours of teammates. The wider team culture therefore became important in determining whether non-selected players continued to feel respected and included.

Informant 4 placed strong emphasis on providing opportunities to players who are currently further behind in the hierarchy. The informant argued that coaches should actively identify situations where these players can receive meaningful playing time:

"*Sometimes I think we are not good enough at seeing that this is a match where we already know that we are the better team. Why should you play your best players*?" *(Informant 4)*

The statement demonstrates a view of playing time as an active developmental tool. Rather than selecting the strongest team in every situation, the informant suggested that coaches should consider when less established players can be given opportunities. Such opportunities could strengthen confidence and provide motivation to remain involved in football. Informant 4 also connected this to inclusion, arguing that young players need to feel that they contribute to the team's progress regardless of their current position in the hierarchy. In this perspective, fairness involved coaches deliberately creating opportunities for players who might otherwise receive less attention.

Informant 5 expressed a more performance-oriented understanding of playing time and selection. Within a high-performance academy environment, the informant accepted that players competing for the same position would not necessarily receive equal opportunities:

"*There is one who plays and the other two stand and watch, maybe their path is not to play in this team, but they have learned*."
(Informant 5)

This perspective provides an important contrast to the other interviews. Informant 5 placed greater emphasis on accepting the selective nature of high-performance football, where current performance can determine who plays. However, the informant still stressed that players who are not selected should be able to learn from those ahead of them and continue developing within the environment. Respect, humility, and solidarity between competing players were described as important values. Fairness, from this perspective, did not mean equal playing time, but rather honest communication and the opportunity to learn even when another player was currently preferred.

Overall, the interviews show that playing time was closely connected to players' experiences of fairness, recognition, and belonging. The informants differed in how equally playing opportunities should be distributed, particularly between broader youth environments and high-performance academies. However, there was a shared concern that players who receive less playing time should not become invisible within the team. Across the interviews, fairness was therefore described less as everyone receiving the same opportunities at all times and more as players understanding decisions, receiving continued feedback, and having meaningful opportunities to develop and contribute to the group. This distinction appears particularly important because limited playing time may affect not only players' development but also their understanding of their value and place within the team.

10. Discussion

The findings of this study highlight five main areas that are particularly relevant for understanding how youth football coaches create a psychologically safe and development-oriented environment while managing performance expectations. The five discussion areas synthesise the six themes identified in the results, as closely related themes were combined in order to discuss the findings more clearly. The discussion will focus on: first, psychological safety in relation to performance demands; second, mastery-oriented approaches to effort, mistakes, and long-term development; third, competition, selection, and fairness; fourth, playing time, recognition, and belonging; and fifth, the coach's role in shaping the psychosocial environment. These areas are discussed in relation to the theoretical framework of Psychological Safety and Achievement Goal Theory, as well as previous research presented earlier in the study.

10.1 Discussion of Main Findings

10.1.1 Psychological Safety and Performance

One of the main findings of this study is that psychological safety and performance were not described as opposing goals. The informants generally accepted that performance demands, competition, and expectations are natural parts of youth football, particularly as players become older and move towards more competitive environments. However, the findings suggest that the way these demands are communicated can influence how players experience them. Rather than removing performance expectations, several informants emphasised the importance of creating an environment where players can deal with pressure without becoming afraid of failure. This suggests that psychological safety may support performance rather than limit it.

This finding is supported by previous research. Walton et al. (2024, p. 558) explain that psychological safety is important in high-performance sport environments where athletes experience strong performance demands and evaluation. Walton et al. (2024, p. 562) further highlight that supportive leadership and clear communication can help athletes express concerns, acknowledge mistakes, and seek support. Haugen et al. (2020, p. 7) similarly found that supportive coach behaviour can influence how young football players experience a performance-oriented climate. Similar patterns were found in the present study, where coaches accepted performance expectations while also emphasising trust, support, and clear communication. This suggests that

performance demands do not necessarily create an unsafe environment, but that the way coaches manage these demands may influence how players experience them.

The findings can also be understood through psychological safety. Edmondson (1999, p. 354) explains that psychological safety allows individuals to take interpersonal risks without fearing negative consequences. In youth football, this may involve asking questions, making mistakes, or attempting difficult actions. Several informants emphasised that players should be able to continue trying after mistakes rather than experiencing immediate criticism or punishment. Psychological safety should therefore not be understood as removing expectations or responsibility, but as creating conditions where players can continue learning under demanding circumstances.

AGTprovides another perspective on this finding. A task-involving climate emphasises effort, learning, and individual improvement, whereas an ego-involving climate places greater emphasis on comparison and demonstrating superior ability (Ames, 1992, p 262; Nicholls, 1984, p. 329). Several informants described performance through effort and development rather than only through results. This indicates that relatively high expectations can remain present while performance is understood through learning and improvement.

At the same time, playing time, selection, comparison with teammates, and current status were described as possible sources of pressure. This suggests that players may become concerned not only about performing poorly, but also about the consequences that poor performance may have for their position within the team. Clear communication and predictable responses from coaches may therefore be particularly important.

Overall, the findings suggest that psychological safety and performance expectations can coexist within youth football. The central issue may not be whether performance demands are present, but how they are communicated and managed. When players understand expectations, receive support, and are allowed to learn from unsuccessful performances, competitive demands may remain compatible with psychological safety and continued development.

10.1.2 A Mastery-Oriented Climate: Effort, Mistakes, and Long-Term Development

A second important finding concerns how the informants described effort, mistakes, and long-term development. Across the interviews, there was a clear tendency to value improvement and learning more than short-term outcomes. The informants did not describe development as something that should be judged only through winning, selection, or current playing status. Instead, they repeatedly focused on effort, continued learning, and the importance of allowing players to develop at different rates. This suggests that several of the coaching approaches described in the study reflect a mastery-oriented way of understanding performance.

This can be connected to Achievement Goal Theory. Ames (1992, p. 262) and Nicholls (1984, p. 329) explain that a mastery-oriented climate places emphasis on effort, learning, personal improvement, and the development of competence. In contrast, a performance-oriented climate focuses more strongly on comparison with others and demonstrating superior ability. The findings in this study largely reflect the first perspective. Informant 1 described performance mainly through effort and what the player can control, while other informants emphasised progress over time rather than immediate success. This indicates that performance was not removed from the environment; rather, it was defined through development, not only through results.

The way mistakes were described also supports this interpretation. Several informants explained that players should be able to make mistakes without being punished or becoming afraid to try again. Informants 1, 2, and 3 especially described mistakes as a natural part of learning and stressed the importance of giving players repeated opportunities to improve. This also connects to psychological safety. Edmondson (1999, p. 354) argues that people are more willing to take interpersonal risks when they do not fear embarrassment or punishment. In youth football, this may include trying a difficult action, asking for help, or continuing after a mistake. If players are encouraged to take risks but are immediately criticised or removed after an unsuccessful action, the coach may create an inconsistent message that reduces trust and willingness to try again.

Previous research also supports this interpretation. Gould et al. (2012, p. 84) found that caring and mastery-oriented climates were associated with more positive developmental experiences among young athletes. Similarly, Fontana et al. (2022, p. 237) found that caring and task-involving climates were negatively associated with sport shame, while ego-involving climates were more strongly related to shame connected to mistakes and results. The findings of the present study

reflect these results, as several coaches described mistakes as a natural part of learning and emphasised effort and continued development rather than immediate success. This suggests that a mastery-oriented approach may help players experience mistakes as part of development rather than as evidence of failure.

Another important part of this finding concerns the long-term perspective on development. Informants 2, 3, and 4 described how young players can become strongly focused on their current position, such as whether they start matches, how much they play, or whether they are ahead of others. The coaches therefore described ways of helping players see development over a longer period, for example by comparing players with their own earlier performances and showing concrete evidence of progress. This reflects a mastery-oriented approach because the focus is placed on individual improvement rather than constant comparison with teammates.

The findings also suggest that a long-term perspective may reduce some of the pressure connected to short-term results. If players attach too much importance to one match, one selection decision, or one period of limited playing time, they may struggle to recognise progress that happens more gradually. Coaches who repeatedly communicate that development takes time may therefore help players understand that temporary setbacks do not define their future development.

10.1.3 Competition, Selection, and the Meaning of Fairness

A third important finding concerns how competition and selection can be managed without creating insecurity among players. All five informants accepted competition as a natural part of football, particularly in older youth and more performance-oriented environments. However, the findings suggest that competition itself was not viewed as the main problem. Instead, insecurity appeared to increase when players did not understand selection decisions, when their position in the team felt constantly threatened, or when competition created negative relationships between teammates. This indicates that the way competition is organised and communicated may be more important than whether competition is present.

This finding can be connected to Achievement Goal Theory. In a performance-oriented climate, players may place greater focus on demonstrating higher ability than others and comparing themselves with teammates (Ames, 1992, p. 262; Nicholls, 1984, p. 329). This can become problematic when selection and playing time are experienced mainly as evidence of who is better or worse. In contrast, several informants described competition in a way that still included learning

and development. Informant 2, for example, emphasised that players should understand what they are working on and how they are developing, while Informant 5 described the importance of "healthy competition," where players can compete for the same position but still respect and learn from each other. These findings suggest that competition does not automatically create an unhealthy performance climate if development and cooperation remain important.

Previous research provides a similar perspective on competition. Ryska and Yin (1999, p. 340) found that recreational youth soccer players reported a stronger mastery-oriented climate than players in competitive leagues. Their findings suggest that more competitive environments may increase the importance of comparison and external standards of success. The present findings partly reflect this, as competition and selection were accepted by the coaches but could create insecurity when players compared themselves with others or were uncertain about their position in the team. However, the findings also suggest that competition does not necessarily become negative when coaches provide clear roles, communication, and continued opportunities for development.

The results also show that predictability may play an important role in how competition is experienced. Informants 1 and 3 stressed that players should understand their roles and the reasons behind selection decisions. Informant 3, for example, described the need for some competition while also providing enough security for players to know their role. This can be connected to psychological safety, as uncertainty may increase when players feel that one poor training session or mistake can immediately change their position. If players understand how decisions are made and what they need to improve, competition may feel more manageable and less threatening.

Another important part of this finding concerns fairness. The informants did not describe fairness as meaning that every player should always receive the same opportunities. Instead, fairness was more often connected to transparency, communication, and continued opportunities for development. This was particularly clear in the differences between Informant 1 and Informant 5. Informant 1 placed greater emphasis on rotation and explaining why players were selected or not selected, while Informant 5 accepted stronger performance-based selection in a high-performance academy environment. Despite these differences, both perspectives included the importance of honesty and ensuring that players understand their situation.

This suggests that fairness in youth football may be better understood as being treated in a clear and respectful way rather than receiving exactly the same outcome. Players may accept different amounts of playing time or different roles if they understand the reasons and continue to feel that the coach is invested in their development. In contrast, unclear decisions may lead players to interpret selection as personal rejection or evidence that they no longer belong in the team.

10.1.4 Playing Time, Recognition, and Belonging

A fourth important finding concerns the connection between playing time, recognition, and the feeling of belonging within the team. Across the interviews, playing time was described as more than a sporting decision. The informants suggested that players may use selection and match minutes as signs of how the coach views them and whether they are considered important members of the team. This means that limited playing time may influence not only development, but also motivation, confidence, and the player's sense of belonging.

This was especially clear in Informant 2's description of game time as an important part of how players see themselves and what they believe the coach thinks about them. The finding suggests that selection decisions can communicate messages beyond the immediate match situation. A player who regularly receives limited playing time may interpret this as a lack of trust, even if the coach has other reasons for the decision. This makes communication particularly important, as players need to understand why decisions are made and what they can continue to work on.

The findings can also be connected to psychological safety. Edmondson (1999, p. 354) explains that psychological safety is related to whether individuals feel accepted and able to participate without fear of negative interpersonal consequences. In youth football, this may also involve feeling that one still belongs to the group despite not being selected. Several informants described the importance of continuing to include players who are further from the starting eleven and making sure that they still receive feedback and opportunities to develop. This suggests that belonging may be maintained when players feel that their development still matters to the coach.

Previous research also points out the importance of feeling of belonging within youth sport environments. Brown et al. (2023, p. 1) describes that social support, belonging, and opportunities for development were important parts of a positive youth sport experience. Similarly, Ooms et al. (2025) describe social belonging and relationships within the sport environment as important for how young people experience participation. The present findings reflect these perspectives, as

coaches emphasised that players who received less playing time should still receive feedback, support, and opportunities to develop. This suggests that limited playing time may not necessarily reduce a player's feeling of belonging if the player continues to feel recognised and included within the team.

At the same time, the informants did not describe fairness as equal playing time for everyone. Instead, fairness was more often connected to continued recognition and meaningful opportunities. Informant 4, for example, argued that coaches should actively identify matches where less established players could receive more playing time. Informant 5, in contrast, accepted that players in a high-performance environment may receive unequal opportunities because of competition and current performance. These differences show that playing time may be managed differently depending on the level and purpose of the environment.

Despite these differences, a common point was that players who receive less playing time should not become invisible. This is important because limited participation may affect how players understand their position in the team. If players are repeatedly excluded without explanation or continued support, they may begin to feel that they are no longer valued. In contrast, regular feedback, honest communication, and meaningful developmental opportunities may help players maintain motivation even when they are not currently selected.

10.1.5 The Coach's Role in the Psychosocial Environment

The final main finding concerns the coach's role in shaping the psychosocial environment. Across the interviews, the informants described safety as something that is created through everyday behaviour rather than through single activities or formal rules. Relationships, communication, structure, and consistency were repeatedly described as important parts of a supportive football environment. This suggests that the coach has a central role in creating the conditions in which players feel secure, understand what is expected of them, and remain involved in their own development.

This finding can be connected to psychological safety. Edmondson (1999, p. 355) explains that psychological safety develops through shared experiences where individuals learn whether it is safe to speak, ask questions, admit mistakes, and take interpersonal risks. In youth football, the coach is an important part of creating these experiences. Several informants described trust as something that develops when coaches are predictable, honest, and consistent in how they

communicate with players. This means that psychological safety may depend less on what coaches say they value and more on whether their everyday behaviour supports those values.

The findings also show that relationships alone are not enough. Informants 2, 3, and 4 placed strong emphasis on clear routines, common expectations, and consistency within the coaching staff. Players were described as more likely to feel secure when they know what is happening, understand the rules, and receive similar messages from different coaches. This suggests that structure and organisation are also important parts of the psychosocial environment. If coaches communicate differently or change expectations without explanation, players may experience uncertainty even when the relationships within the team are generally positive.

Previous research supports the importance of both coach leadership and the wider environment surrounding young players. Vella et al. (2013, p. 556) found that transformational leadership behaviours and the quality of the coach-athlete relationship were positively related to developmental experiences among adolescent football players. Crawley and Hills (2023, p. 54) also showed that communication, organisational culture, and shared understanding influenced psychosocial development within an elite youth football environment. The findings of the present study reflect these perspectives, as the coaches emphasised relationships, clear communication, consistency, and structure as important parts of the psychosocial environment. This suggests that the coach's role involves both building relationships with individual players and creating a clear and predictable environment for the team.

At the same time, several informants emphasised the need to understand players as individuals. Informant 1 described the importance of adapting communication to different personalities, while Informant 5 stressed that coaches need to understand what may be happening in a player's life outside football. This indicates that creating a supportive environment also requires social awareness. Coaches may need to challenge different players in different ways depending on their confidence, circumstances, and individual needs. However, this individual approach still needs to exist within a clear and consistent team structure.

The findings also suggest that the psychosocial environment is not created by one coach alone. Informant 4 highlighted the importance of alignment within the coaching staff, while other informants discussed the influence of teammates, parents, and the wider club environment. This means that coaches operate within a broader social system where different messages can either

support or weaken the climate they are trying to create. A coach may therefore play a central role, but creating psychological safety also requires cooperation between leaders and consistency across the wider football environment.

10.2 Methodological Discussion

The qualitative research design was considered suitable for the purpose of this study because it allowed the coaches to describe their experiences and perspectives in their own words. The use of semi-structured interviews provided a common structure across the five interviews while also allowing follow-up questions when relevant topics were raised. This flexibility was useful when discussing issues such as performance expectations, mistakes, competition, playing time, and psychological safety. As described by Jones (2015, p. 177), semi-structured interviews allow participants to develop their answers while the researcher remains focused on the main topics of the study.

Thematic analysis was also considered appropriate because it allowed recurring patterns across the interviews to be identified and organised into themes. However, Braun et al. (2016, p. 192) emphasise that themes are developed through the researcher's interpretation rather than simply discovered in the data. The analysis was therefore influenced by decisions regarding which responses were considered relevant, how codes were grouped, and how the final themes were defined.

Another methodological consideration is that the interviews reflect the coaches' descriptions of their own practices. The method can therefore provide insight into how coaches understand psychological safety and performance expectations, but it cannot determine whether their described practices are always applied in everyday coaching. Direct observations could have provided another perspective on whether the behaviours described during the interviews were also visible in practice.

10.3 Limitations

There are several limitations that need to be considered when interpreting the findings of this study. The first limitation concerns the relatively small number of participants. As the study used a qualitative research design, the purpose was to gain a deeper understanding of how youth football coaches describe psychological safety, performance expectations, and player

development rather than to produce findings that can be generalised to all youth football environments. However, the small sample means that the perspectives presented in this study cannot be assumed to represent how all youth football coaches understand or manage these issues. A larger sample could potentially have provided a wider range of experiences and perspectives.

A second limitation is that the participants were recruited from football environments within Skåne. Although the coaches had different levels of experience and worked in different football environments, all participants were recruited from Skåne. The findings may therefore not fully represent youth football environments in other parts of Sweden or in other countries. These may differ in their organizational structures, resources, coaching philosophies, and expectations regarding player development and performance. Therefore, the findings should primarily be understood in relation to the contexts represented by the participants in this study.

Another important limitation is that the study only examines the perspectives of coaches. The findings therefore describe how coaches understand and believe they create a psychologically safe and development-oriented environment. However, this does not necessarily mean that players experience the environment in the same way. For example, a coach may consider communication, selection decisions, or performance expectations to be clear and supportive, while a player may experience the same situation differently. Including youth players could therefore have provided another perspective on psychological safety, fairness, playing time, competition, and performance pressure.

10.4 Conclusion

The aim of this study was to explore how youth football coaches create a psychologically safe and development-oriented environment while managing different performance expectations. The findings show that psychological safety, performance demands, competition, and player development are closely connected rather than separate parts of the football environment. Across the five interviews, the coaches generally accepted that expectations, competition, selection, and mistakes are natural parts of youth football. However, the way these situations are communicated and managed appeared important for whether players experience them as developmental challenges or as sources of pressure and insecurity.

One of the main conclusions is that psychological safety and performance should not necessarily be understood as opposing goals. The coaches described safe environments as places where

players can make mistakes, ask questions, and continue trying while still being expected to improve and perform. High expectations were therefore not considered problematic by themselves. Instead, difficulties appeared when expectations were connected to uncertainty, unclear consequences, or constant comparison with other players. This suggests that coaches can maintain demanding environments while still supporting psychological safety through clear communication, consistency, and opportunities for players to recover from mistakes.

The findings also highlight the importance of a development-oriented approach. Several coaches focused on effort, learning, and individual progress rather than only on winning, selection, or current status. Mistakes were generally described as part of the learning process, while long-term development was considered more important than short-term results. This indicates that coaches can influence how players understand performance by directing attention towards factors that players can control. Helping players recognise their own progress may also reduce the importance attached to temporary setbacks or comparison with teammates.

Competition and selection were another important part of the findings. The coaches did not argue that competition should be removed from youth football. Instead, the challenge was to create competition without allowing it to damage trust, relationships, or belonging. Fairness did not necessarily mean equal playing time for every player. Rather, it was connected to players understanding decisions, receiving honest feedback, and continuing to have opportunities to develop. Playing time was particularly important because players may interpret selection as an indication of how much the coach values them. Coaches therefore need to recognise that sporting decisions can also have psychosocial consequences.

Finally, the findings show the central role of the coach in shaping the psychosocial environment. Psychological safety appears to develop through everyday interactions, including how coaches communicate expectations, respond to mistakes, organise competition, explain selection decisions, and build relationships with players. Clear structures and consistent communication may provide players with predictability, while individual relationships can help coaches understand how different players experience pressure and competition.

Although this study focused specifically on youth football, several of the findings may also be relevant to coaches in other youth sports. Issues such as competition, playing time, performance expectations, mistakes, relationships, and communication are not unique to football and may also

influence the psychosocial environment in other sporting contexts. The findings therefore suggest that coaches across different sports may benefit from emphasising learning, clear communication, fairness, and long-term development while still maintaining appropriate performance expectations. However, because the study was based on five football coaches, the findings should not be assumed to apply directly to all sports, and their relevance may depend on the specific demands and culture of each sporting environment.

10.5 Future Research

Future research could develop the findings of this study in several ways. One important direction would be to examine the perspectives of youth football players themselves. The present study focuses on how coaches describe psychological safety, performance expectations, mistakes, competition, and player development. However, coaches and players may not always experience the same environment in the same way. Including player perspectives could therefore provide a broader understanding of how psychologically safe and development-oriented environments are experienced in practice.

A second area concerns differences between age groups. The findings suggest that competition, selection, playing time, and status may become more important as players grow older and move towards more performance-oriented environments. Future studies could compare younger and older players to examine whether psychological safety and performance pressure are experienced differently across developmental stages.

Gender is another relevant area for further research. The present study does not examine differences between boys' and girls' football environments, meaning that no conclusions about gender can be drawn from the current findings. Future studies could compare how male and female youth players experience coach communication, mistakes, competition, performance expectations, and psychological safety.

Overall, these areas could contribute to a broader understanding of how psychological safety and performance expectations are created and experienced in youth football. Player perspectives, age differences, gender comparisons, and direct observation of coaching behaviour could all provide important knowledge for future research.

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Appendix

Interview guide (Swedish)

Introduktion.

- Jag presenterar mig själva och syftet med intervjun
- Berättar att jag använder en semistrukturerad intervju
- Jag berättar strukturen och längden på intervjun
- Jag berättar om forskningsetiska regler och att samtalet kommer att spelas in är okej och att de har rätten att avbryta när de vill och att materialet inte kommer att användas.
- Nämn samtyckes blänket
- Inspelningen startar

Bakgrund

- Skulle du kunna presentera dig lite kort?
- Ålder?
- Vilken ålderträna re du just nu.
- Hur länge har du varit tränare inom Fotboll
- Vad innefattar ditt uppdrag? Yttre/inre tjänst?
- Heltid, deltid, annat arbete vid sidan om?

Psychological safety

1. Hur skulle du beskriva en trygg och bra miljö i ett ungdomslag?

- Till exempel för att spelarna ska känna sig fria från prestationsångest?

- Vad kännetecknar en sådan miljö, enligt dig?

- Hur tror du att en sådan miljö påverkar spelarna?

- Vilken betydelse tror du att en trygg miljö har för spelares självförtroende och prestationsångest?

- Finns det andra personer än tränaren som kan bidra till en sådan miljö?

- Hur kan dessa personer involveras?

2. Vilken betydelse har relationen mellan tränare och spelare för att skapa en god miljö? Så att spelare känner sig hörda, respekterade och inkluderade i laget, oavsett nivå eller position?

- Vad i relationen mellan tränare och spelare anser du vara viktigast?
- Hur märks det när en spelare känner sig hörd och respekterad?
- Hur kan tränarens sätt att kommunicera påverka denna relation?
- Hur tror du att relationen påverkar spelarnas trygghet i laget?

3. Hur tror du att konkurrens om speltid eller prestation kan påverka den psykologiska tryggheten i ett lag, enligt dig?

- På vilket sätt kan konkurrens påverka spelarnas trygghet positivt eller negativt?
- Hur tror du att spelarna själva påverkar detta klimat?
- Finns det andra faktorer som kan förstärka eller minska den här påverkan?
- Hur kan tränare hantera konkurrens utan att tryggheten försämras?

4. Utifrån din syn på lagmiljön, hur kan tränare stödja spelare som känner sig osäkra eller otillräckliga i laget?

- Hur kan tränare stärka dessa spelares tro på sin egen förmåga?
- Hur kan tränare ge feedback i sådana situationer?
- Hur kan man stötta spelare utan att öka deras prestationspress?
- Vad tror du är viktigt för att få spelare att tänka mer långsiktigt kring sin utveckling?

5. Vad anser du att tränare behöver göra i vardagen för att långsiktigt bygga en trygg och utvecklande lagmiljö?

- Vilka vardagliga handlingar tror du har störst betydelse?
- Vad krävs för att en sådan miljö ska hålla över tid?
- Vilka hinder kan finnas i det arbetet?
- Finns det något som tränare ofta underskattar i detta sammanhang?

Achievement goal theory

1. Vad är din syn på balansen mellan en trygg lagmiljö och en prestationsinriktad miljö i ungdomsfotboll?

- Går det att skapa en balans mellan dessa, enligt dig?
- Vilken roll har spelarna i att forma en sådan miljö?
- Vilken roll har tränaren i detta?
- Finns det risker om fokus blir för starkt åt ena hållet?

2. Vad anser du kännetecknar en miljö där spelare främst fokuserar på lärande och utveckling?

- Vad tror du gör att spelare fokuserar på utveckling snarare än jämförelse?
- Hur påverkar en sådan miljö, spelarnas motivation?
- Hur tror du att spelare upplever en sådan miljö?
- Uppflytning?

3. Hur uppfattar du att fokus på resultat och vinster påverkar spelarnas prestationsångest i ungdomsfotboll?

- Hur tror du att ett starkt resultatfokus påverkar spelarnas motivation?
- Vilken roll tror du att spelarna själva har i detta?
- Vad tror du kan minska negativa effekter av ett starkt resultatfokus?
- Hur påverkas spelare på olika nivåer av detta, tror du?

4. Vad anser du att tränare behöver göra i vardagen för att långsiktigt balansera lagets mål att vinna med varje spelares långsiktiga mål att utvecklas individuellt?

- Vilka utmaningar kan finnas i att skapa en sådan balans?
- Hur tror du att spelarna påverkas när balansen fungerar bra?

- Vad händer när fokus på att vinna blir för dominerande?
- Hur kan tränare kommunicera denna balans till spelarna?

Avslutning

- Jag gör en sammanfattning av intervjun och tackar att de har viljat ställa upp på vår intervju.
- Frågar om personen känner att de har något att säga som inte har blivit sagt inom området eller har några andra frågor.
- Intervjun avslutas och jag tackar för mig.

Interview Guide (English)

Introduction

- Introduce myself and explain the purpose of the interview.
- Explain that a semi-structured interview format will be used.
- Explain the structure and expected length of the interview.
- Explain the research ethical principles, including that the interview will be recorded, participation is voluntary, and the participant has the right to withdraw at any time.
- Mention the informed consent form.
- Start the recording.

Background

- Could you briefly introduce yourself?
- How old are you?
- What age group are you currently coaching?
- How long have you been a football coach?
- What does your current role involve? Do you have responsibilities beyond coaching the team?
- Do you work full-time, part-time, or have another job alongside your coaching role?

Psychological Safety

1. How would you describe a safe and positive environment in a youth football team?

- For example, an environment where players can feel free from performance anxiety?
- What characterises such an environment, in your opinion?
- How do you think such an environment affects the players?
- What importance do you think a safe environment has for players' self-confidence and performance anxiety?
- Are there people other than the coach who can contribute to creating such an environment?
- How can these people be involved?

2. What importance does the relationship between coach and player have for creating a positive environment in which players feel heard, respected, and included in the team, regardless of their level or position?

- What do you consider most important in the relationship between coach and player?
- How can you tell when a player feels heard and respected?
- How can the coach's way of communicating influence this relationship?
- How do you think the relationship affects players' sense of safety within the team?

3. How do you think competition for playing time or performance can affect psychological safety within a team?

- In what ways can competition affect players' sense of safety positively or negatively?
- How do you think the players themselves influence this climate?
- Are there other factors that can strengthen or reduce this effect?
- How can coaches manage competition without negatively affecting psychological safety?

4. Based on your view of the team environment, how can coaches support players who feel insecure or inadequate within the team?

- How can coaches strengthen these players' belief in their own abilities?
- How can coaches provide feedback in these situations?
- How can players be supported without increasing performance pressure?
- What do you think is important in helping players take a more long-term perspective on their development?

5. What do you think coaches need to do in their everyday practice to build a safe and development-oriented team environment over the long term?

- Which everyday actions do you think are most important?
- What is required for such an environment to be maintained over time?
- What challenges or barriers may arise in this work?
- Is there anything that coaches often underestimate in this context?

Achievement Goal Theory

1. What is your view on the balance between a psychologically safe team environment and a performance-oriented environment in youth football?

- Do you think it is possible to create a balance between the two?
- What role do the players have in shaping such an environment?
- What role does the coach have?
- Are there risks if the focus becomes too strong in either direction?

2. What do you think characterises an environment in which players primarily focus on learning and development?

- What do you think encourages players to focus on development rather than comparison with others?
- How does such an environment affect players' motivation?
- How do you think players experience such an environment?
- How might moving up to an older or higher-level team affect this?

3. How do you perceive the influence of a focus on results and winning on players' performance anxiety in youth football?

- How do you think a strong focus on results affects players' motivation?
- What role do you think the players themselves have in this?
- What do you think can reduce the negative effects of a strong focus on results?
- How do you think players at different levels are affected by this?

4. What do you think coaches need to do in their everyday practice to balance the team's goal of winning with each player's long-term goal of individual development?

- What challenges may arise when trying to create this balance?
- How do you think players are affected when this balance works well?
- What happens when the focus on winning becomes too dominant?
- How can coaches communicate this balance to the players?

Conclusion

- Summarise the main points of the interview and thank the participant for taking part.
- Ask whether the participant has anything else they would like to add that has not been discussed, or whether they have any questions.
- End the interview and thank the participant for their participation.

Participations letter

Missivbrev

Bakgrund

Jag heter Marcus Engström och är student vid Malmö universitet där jag läser tvåårigt mastersprogram i idrottsvetenskap. Inom ramen för min masteruppsats undersöker jag frågor relaterade till psykosocial trygg miljö och hur man kan bibehålla en hög prestation inom svensk fotboll.

Syfte

jag jobbar för tillfället på min masteruppsats som kommer att behandla Hur man kan bygga en psykologisk trygg miljö inom fotbollen. Det jag försöker ta reda på är vad tränare kan göra för att bygga en sådan trygg miljö som möjligt som får spelare att känna sig uppmärksam och trygg, inom en fotbollsmiljö. Jag vill även undersöka om det går att kombinera detta med att ha höga standard och förväntningar på spelare

Urval

Ni har blivit utvalda med hänvisning till urvalskriterier: att ni har en aktiv tränarroll inom en ungdomsfotbollsförening.

Metod

Jag kommer genomföra en kvalitativ studie genom att hålla en inspelad intervju som varar cirka 30–45 minuter, antingen fysiskt eller digitalt på en plats som deltagaren önskar.

Forskningsetiska principer

Jag kommer att ta hänsyn till forskningsetiska principer där data behandlas konfidentiellt och där resultatet enbart används för forskningsändamål. Deltagandet är frivilligt, anonymt och informant kan vid vilket tillfälle som helst avbryta intervjun eller avstå från att svara på någon fråga.

Efter avslutad studie kommer all data raderas och en godkänd uppsats kommer att publiceras på www.diva-portal.org som en offentlig handling för allmänheten att kunna ta del av.

Övrigt

Mer information om samtycke och studien finner du längre ned i detta dokument. För vidare information och eventuella frågor och överenskommelser är ni välkomna att kontakta mig på mail eller telefon som följer här nedan.

Marcus Engström
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0708-50 00 20

Samtycke till medverkan i studie gällande hur man bygger en trygg psykosocial miljö inom svensk ungdomsfotboll.

Bakgrund

Denna studie undersöker hur ungdomsfotbollstränare arbetar för att skapa och upprätthålla en god psykosocial miljö i laget samtidigt som de hanterar krav på prestation och resultat. Bakgrunden till studien är att ungdomsidrotten ofta präglas av både utvecklingsmål och tävlingskrav, vilket kan påverka spelarnas trygghet, motivation och välmående. Tidigare forskning visar att tränarens ledarskap, kommunikation och sätt att organisera träning och återkoppling har stor betydelse för hur spelare upplever sin idrottsmiljö. Därför är det relevant att undersöka hur tränare resonerar kring balans mellan utveckling, prestation och psykologisk trygghet i ungdomsfotboll. Studien kan bidra med kunskap som stärker tränarrollen i praktiken.

Syfte

Syftet med studien är att undersöka ungdomsfotbollstränares perspektiv på hur man kan arbeta för att skapa en god psykosocial miljö som hjälper spelarna att minska sin prestationsångest, samtidigt som man har höga prestationskrav. Studien vill också bidra till ökad förståelse för hur tränarnas ledarskap, kommunikation och återkoppling påverkar spelarnas upplevelser av lagmiljön och deras möjligheter att utvecklas.

Student

Marcus Engström

Medverkan baseras på samtycke och detta samtycke kan när som helst återkallas.

Jag har läst och förstått informationen om studien. Jag har fått möjlighet att ställa frågor och jag har fått dem besvarade. Jag får behålla den skriftliga informationen.

☐ Jag samtycker till att delta i studien som beskrivs i dokumentet.

☐ Jag samtycker till att mina personuppgifter behandlas på det sätt som beskrivs i dokumentet.

Härmed samtycker jag till att medverka i studie gällande psykologisk trygghet och prestationskrav inom ungdomsfotboll

Datum, underskrift och namnförtydligande informant/medverkande person

……

Datum, underskrift och namnförtydligande ansvarig student/projektledare/annan:

……

Kontaktuppgifter

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0708-50 00 20

Malmö universitet: www.mau.se
040-665 70 00

Information om Malmö Universitets behandling av personuppgifter

Personuppgiftsansvarig	Malmö universitet är forskningshuvudman
Dataskyddsombud	dataskyddsombud@mau.se
Typ av personuppgifter	Enbart intervjusvar
Ändamål med behandlingen	För att möjliggöra genomförandet av examensarbete vid Malmö universitet.
Rättslig grund för behandling	Ditt samtycke.
Mottagare	Personuppgifterna kommer endast att användas inom ramen för min studie gällande psykologisk trygghet och prestationskrav inom ungdomsfotbollen vid Malmö universitet och kommer inte otillbörligt att spridas vidare till någon annan mottagare.
Lagringstid	Malmö universitet kommer att spara dina personuppgifter så länge de behövs för ovan angivet ändamål eller till dess att du återkallar ditt samtycke. Källdata/personuppgifter sparas i 6 månader och raderas därefter.
Dina rättigheter	Du har rätt att kontakta Malmö universitet för att 1) få information om vilka uppgifter Malmö universitet har om dig och 2) begära rättelse av dina uppgifter. Vidare, och under de förutsättningar som närmare anges i dataskyddslagstiftningen, har du rätt att 3) begära radering av dina uppgifter, 4) begära en överföring av dina uppgifter (dataportabilitet), eller 5) begära att Malmö universitet begränsar behandlingen av dina uppgifter. När Malmö universitet behandlar personuppgifter med stöd av ditt samtycke, har du rätt att när som helst återkalla ditt samtycke genom meddelande till Malmö universitet. Du har rätt att inge klagomål om Malmö universitets behandling av dina personuppgifter genom att kontakta Integritetsskyddsmyndighen